

Chapter One

WHERE IS EVERYBODY

The training room at Base 45 smelled the way it always did: rubber, mild disinfectant, and the faint metallic undertone that nobody had ever managed to identify or eliminate. It was early enough in the morning that the overhead lights had not yet reached full brightness, and the long rows of equipment sat in a pale, half-lit quiet.

Benny Mischief was not there. This was unusual only in the sense that Benny was usually everywhere, or at minimum audible from everywhere, and the silence he left behind had a texture to it, the kind of quiet that made the room feel slightly larger than it was.

What was there, positioned in the far corner beside the reinforced wall panel, was Mr. Bobbin.

He stood, as he always stood, on his metal pole, his leather surface creased and patched and decorated across its midriff with a galaxy of stickers accumulated over what the gym staff estimated was several decades. A crayon drawing of a sun. A badge that read UNDEFEATED, awarded ironically by a recruit who had spent forty minutes trying to land a single clean hit. A small adhesive lightning bolt that someone had placed on his chest so long ago that the edges had begun to peel and nobody had the heart to finish removing it.

His face, two round eyes and a smiling mouth drawn in thick black marker, looked out at the room with the calm, cheerful authority of something that had never once been struck and had never once been worried about it.

Bás Eagla entered from the east corridor.

He moved the way he always moved inside the base: quietly, without announcing himself, his long dark robe making no sound against the floor. The skull-adorned mask, moulded to represent Scath bone structure in precise anatomical detail, caught the low morning light as he turned his head and

assessed the room in a single sweep. His bright green eyes, the only part of him that was not pitch black, settled briefly on Mr. Bobbin.

He gave the dummy a small nod. Acknowledgment, not greeting. The distinction mattered.

Mr. Bobbin swayed almost imperceptibly to the left.

Bás Eagla crossed the room and sat on the bench along the near wall, setting down a thin folder and folding his hands over it. He waited. Waiting was not difficult for him. He had spent most of his life developing the patience required to exist in a world that had not been built with him in mind, and he had found, over time, that patience was simply another form of attention.

He was aware, through the passive hum of The Mind, of the position of every person in the building. He could feel the agents two floors up beginning their morning routines. He could feel the two technicians in the equipment bay and the single administrator at the front desk reading something that was making her quietly irritated. He filtered most of it out, as he usually did, keeping only the soft peripheral awareness that functioned less like surveillance and more like having a very large sense of the space around you.

He was also aware of Zephyr approaching the corridor.

The awareness arrived a few seconds before the sound did, and then the sound arrived: a low, tuneless hum, slightly off-key, punctuated by the rhythmic squeak of training shoes on the hallway floor that suggested someone was moving in a manner that could charitably be described as a walk.

Zephyr came through the door at approximately six feet seven inches of neon bodysuit and barely contained morning energy. The suit shifted through its usual slow cycling of colour, settling at that moment somewhere between electric teal and a warm amber that had no business existing at this hour. His mask displayed a cheerful expression, round eyes curving upward.

"Morning," Zephyr said, with the enthusiasm of someone who had already decided the day was going to be good and was not especially open to counterarguments.

Bás Eagla looked up from the folder.

"You are four minutes late."

"I was dancing."

"That is not an explanation."

"It absolutely is." Zephyr dropped into the bench beside him with a force that made the frame protest audibly. He looked around the room, saw Mr. Bobbin, and raised one hand in a wave. "Morning, Bobbin."

Mr. Bobbin swayed gently. Possibly toward him. It was difficult to say.

"Where is Benny?" Zephyr asked.

"Working on something." Bás Eagla did not elaborate, because he did not know more than that, and he was not in the habit of speculating aloud. What he knew was that Benny had left a note on the briefing board two days ago that read GENIUS AT WORK, UNAVAILABLE, and that nobody had questioned this because nobody ever questioned Benny's notes, partly out of respect and partly out of the practical understanding that questioning them rarely produced useful information.

Zephyr accepted this with a nod and looked at the folder.

"So. What is the briefing?"

Bás Eagla opened the folder.

He read in the same way he spoke: steadily, without ornamentation, giving each word its weight and no more.

"Seven individuals currently under ISP observation have not made scheduled contact. The periods of silence range from eleven days to just over three

weeks. None of the gaps are long enough to trigger a formal emergency protocol, but the directorate considers the pattern irregular enough to warrant direct welfare checks." He paused. "We are assigned to conduct them in person."

Zephyr's mask shifted to an expression of mild curiosity.

"All seven?"

"All seven."

"Where?"

Bás Eagla turned the page.

"El Salvador. New York. Scotland. Sweden. Greece. Tanzania. Japan."

A pause.

"That is," Zephyr said thoughtfully, "a lot of places."

"Yes."

"Are we taking the jet?"

"We are taking the jet."

Zephyr's mask settled into something that looked, as best as a flat display could manage, like quiet satisfaction. He had opinions about air travel, most of them positive, and most of them centred on the amount of space available and the relative absence of anyone telling him to stop moving around.

"When do we leave?"

"This afternoon." Bás Eagla closed the folder. "The first contact is in El Salvador. I will read the full dossier on the flight." He stood, picking up the folder and settling it under one arm. He glanced once more at Mr. Bobbin. The dummy's marker-drawn smile held steady, patient and permanent and unoffended by the morning.

"We should pack," Bás Eagla said.

"I do not really pack," Zephyr said.

"I am aware." Bás Eagla moved toward the corridor. "I said we should pack. I was including myself."

Zephyr stood, stretched in a way that used most of the available vertical space in the room, and followed.

Mr. Bobbin swayed once, very slightly, in the direction of the door after they left.

Nobody saw it happen. Nobody ever did.

The jet departed Base 45 at fourteen hundred hours.

It was not a large aircraft, but it was well-equipped, built to ISP specifications with enough range to connect most of the route without refuelling stops and enough interior space that two agents of notably different sizes could occupy the same cabin without feeling like they were being compressed against each other. The seating was functional and not uncomfortable. There was a narrow galley. There were windows.

Zephyr had immediately claimed the window seat, which Bás Eagla had expected, and had spent the first twenty minutes of the flight watching the Chilean coastline recede with an expression that the mask rendered as something between wonder and contentment.

Bás Eagla read.

He had brought the full stack of dossiers. Seven contacts, seven files, each one a profile assembled from ISP intake records, field reports, and whatever biographical information the individuals had provided or the organisation had gathered. He read the way he did most things: completely, without skimming, committing each detail to the part of his memory that he would be able to access cleanly when he needed it.

After a while, Zephyr turned away from the window.

"Read it out," he said.

Bás Eagla looked up.

"The first one," Zephyr said. "Read it out. So I know what we are walking into."

Bás Eagla considered this for a moment, then looked back down at the first file and began to read.

Chapter Two

THE WRONG WAY TO SAY HELLO

Bás Eagla opened the first dossier and read without preamble.

"Subject: Jesús. Species designation, winged human, South American origin. Status listed as active, unaffiliated, independent operator. Classification by the ISP intake committee is anti-hero, vigilante-type."

Zephyr had turned away from the window and was now facing forward, which for him constituted paying attention.

"Physical profile. Age appearance, early to mid twenties. Build described as well built and athletic, with calloused hands. Hair, buzzcut, dark. Attire noted as non-tactical, consisting of a white tank top, frequently stained, baggy trousers, worn boots. The file specifies he looks more like a street kid than a soldier. Wings, two in total, asymmetrical in colour. One pitch black, one gold. Each spanning two and a half metres. Right side of the body, flesh and wing both, bears significant burn scarring of personal history origin."

Zephyr considered this.

"Asymmetrical wings," he said.

"That is what the file states."

"One black, one gold."

"Yes."

A pause.

"That is," Zephyr said, with the measured tone of someone trying to sound neutral and not quite managing it, "genuinely cool."

Bás Eagla did not respond to this and continued reading.

"Personality. The intake profile uses the following descriptors: sarcastic, biting humour, deflection dressed as wit. No patience for hypocrisy, particularly from authority figures. Loyal in what the file terms a scorched-earth manner. Operates by his own code, which does not align consistently with ISP doctrine. Willing to use lethal force when he judges it necessary and does not consider this a moral failing." Bás Eagla paused briefly over the next line, then read it without inflection. "The file notes a deep, carefully concealed self-loathing beneath the bravado, connected to a childhood in which the wings that now define his capabilities were weaponised against him as a source of shame."

The cabin was quiet for a moment except for the engine noise.

"His father," Bás Eagla continued, "was the primary source of that abuse. Physical and psychological, sustained, targeting the wings specifically. His mother, by contrast, was the only consistent source of protection and care available to him during that period. The father is no longer in the picture. The file does not specify further, and it is not relevant to the current assignment."

He closed the dossier.

"He has not made contact in sixteen days. His registered address is in a residential district on the outskirts of San Salvador. We go there first."

Zephyr looked out the window again at the cloud cover below them, thinking.

"He does not like authority figures," he said.

"No."

"And we are, technically speaking, authority figures."

"We represent an organisation with an institutional structure, yes."

"So he is probably not going to be happy to see us."

"That is a reasonable inference."

Zephyr nodded slowly, with the air of someone filing useful information away for later. Then his mask shifted into something that looked like forward-facing optimism, and he turned back to the window.

Bás Eagla returned the dossier to the folder and looked out at his own side of the sky, and said nothing further, because there was nothing further that needed saying.

San Salvador arrived the way most cities arrived from the air: as a sprawl that organised itself into detail only as the altitude dropped. The jet put them down at a private airstrip on the eastern edge of the metropolitan area, and from there a ground vehicle handled the rest.

The district where Jesús was registered was not the kind of neighbourhood that appeared in the parts of any tourism material. The streets were narrow and the buildings were close together, the kind of close that came not from planning but from necessity, each structure built in the available gaps left by the ones that had come before. Laundry lines crossed overhead. Paint peeled in long strips from most of the visible walls. The ground was uneven and the gutters were full in the way they always were after rain, which it had been, recently, the streets still carrying the particular smell of wet concrete and vegetation that was not entirely unpleasant if you were not looking for reasons to dislike the place.

Bás Eagla walked ahead, robe dark and quiet against the midday light. Zephyr walked beside him and drew considerably more attention, as Zephyr always did everywhere, because a six-foot-seven figure in a shifting neon bodysuit was not something any neighbourhood was entirely prepared for regardless of context. Several children stopped to stare. A man sitting outside a doorway watched them pass with the expression of someone who had decided that whatever this was, it was not his problem.

The address in the file corresponded to a building set slightly back from the main lane, accessible through a narrow passage between two larger structures. There was no number visible on the door, but Bás Eagla had read the file

description carefully enough to be certain of the location. He stopped outside it and looked at the door for a moment.

He knocked.

Nothing.

He knocked again, with the particular quality of knock that communicated clearly that he was prepared to knock a third time and a fourth if necessary and would not be interpreting silence as a conclusive answer.

Still nothing.

"He is not here," Zephyr said.

"Or he is here and choosing not to answer."

"Also possible."

Bás Eagla looked at the door, then at the frame, then made a decision that was not especially difficult given the circumstances and the urgency level of the assignment. He pressed his hand flat against the door and let his form shift, becoming shadow, becoming flat and dimensionless, and slipped through the gap at the base of the frame. A moment later the latch clicked from the inside and the door swung open.

Zephyr stepped in.

The interior was small and practical and bore no particular signs of anything having gone wrong inside it. A cot along one wall, neatly made in the perfunctory way of someone who had learned to do it out of habit rather than care. A worktable along the other wall, and this was the part of the room that held attention: it was covered in tools. Not in a chaotic way, but in the way of someone with a very specific and rigorous relationship to their equipment. Gunsmithing tools arranged by function. Cleaning supplies organised by use. Several parts in various stages of assembly, each sitting on a square of cloth to protect the table surface. A lamp angled precisely over the work area.

"He lives here," Zephyr said, looking around.

"He lives here," Bás Eagla confirmed, doing his own survey of the room. Nothing overturned. No signs of hasty departure. No signs of struggle. The window was latched from the inside. The floor had dust in the corners but not the kind of dust that accumulated when a space was abandoned; it was the dust of a place that got cleaned irregularly but did get cleaned.

On the worktable, beside a partially assembled firing mechanism, there was a photograph. It was not framed. It was held flat by the weight of a small metal component sitting on one corner, the casual kind of weight you put on something you looked at often and did not want to lose to a draft. The photograph showed two people. A young man whose face was turned slightly away from the camera, and a woman beside him whose expression was direct and whose posture had the quality of someone who stood in front of things rather than behind them.

Bás Eagla looked at the photograph for a moment.

Through The Mind, he was already aware of the building's immediate surroundings, the quiet hum of other lives in adjacent structures, a dog somewhere to the left, traffic noise filtering from the main lane. Nothing that indicated a threat. Nothing that indicated Jesús was anywhere nearby.

"We wait outside," he said.

They left the room as they had found it, Bás Eagla pulling the door shut behind him, and returned to the narrow passage.

They did not have to wait long.

The woman appeared at the far end of the passage maybe ten minutes later. She was walking with the practiced efficiency of someone who knew this route well and was carrying two bags, neither of them light. She was perhaps fifty, her hair pulled back, wearing the kind of practical clothing that had nothing to do with presentation and everything to do with the day's requirements. She turned into the passage without looking up and was most of the way down it

before she registered that two individuals she had never seen were standing outside her son's door.

She stopped.

She looked at them.

Bás Eagla, to his credit, recognised immediately the specific quality of the look on her face. It was not the look of someone who had never seen anything strange. It was the look of a woman who had raised a child with black and gold wings in a neighbourhood that was not interested in protecting him, who had spent years being the only line between her son and a world that wanted to make him smaller, and who had developed, as a consequence, a threat-assessment reflex that operated fast and did not require context.

She drew breath and she screamed.

It was a short, sharp, involuntary sound, pure alarm, the kind of noise a person makes not as a call for help but simply because the body makes it before the mind can intervene. It echoed off the close walls of the passage and then she clamped it down immediately, pressing her lips together and squaring her shoulders, and Bás Eagla could see her recalibrating very quickly from terror to something harder and more defensive.

But the sound had already gone out.

Above the roofline, something moved.

He came down fast.

That was the first thing. There was no circling, no warning, no attempt to assess the situation from altitude. The shadow of the black wing hit the passage first, and then Jesús landed at the entrance in a single sharp drop that sent the loose debris on the ground skittering outward. He was exactly what the dossier had described and also not quite what the dossier had prepared for, because a file could tell you two and a half metres per wing but it could

not tell you how much space a person took up when they were using them and furious simultaneously.

The gold wing and the black wing spread to their full span in the narrow passage, the tips nearly brushing both walls, and the burn scarring on his right side caught the light, and the expression on his face was completely uncomplicated.

He pulled the Chiappa from his hip and had it levelled in the same motion.

"Get away from her," he said.

His voice was not loud. That was the second thing. He did not need to be loud.

Bás Eagla did not move. He had identified, through The Mind, everything that had happened in the last thirty seconds: the woman's fear, the sound, the shift of weight above the roofline before the landing, the trajectory and speed of the descent. He had also, in the same moment, identified the precise emotional state of the person now pointing a modified firearm at him, and that state was not aggression for its own sake. It was specific and targeted and completely coherent given the situation.

He raised both hands, slowly, palms out.

Zephyr, beside him, had not moved either, though his mask had shifted to an expression that was doing its best to communicate that he was aware this was a tense moment and was taking it seriously.

"We are not here to threaten her," Bás Eagla said. His voice was steady and unhurried. "We are not here to threaten you. We are agents of the International Security Program. You are in our records as a person of interest under observation, and you have missed sixteen days of scheduled contact. We were sent to verify your wellbeing."

Jesús did not lower the gun.

"ISP," he said. The word had a specific flatness to it, the kind that was not ignorance but its exact opposite.

"Yes."

"You broke into my house."

"We confirmed you were not inside and exited without disturbing anything."

"That is breaking in."

"It is a narrow distinction," Bás Eagla acknowledged. "Under the circumstances, one I chose to make."

Jesús looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at Zephyr. Zephyr's mask was displaying an expression that on a human face would have corresponded roughly to a cautious wave.

The gun did not lower.

"Jesús," the woman said, from behind Bás Eagla and Zephyr. Her voice was quieter than the scream had been. It had a different texture, the kind of voice that had stopped a lot of things over the years by being exactly what it was.

Something in Jesús shifted. Not much. Not visibly. But Bás Eagla felt it through The Mind, a small recalibration, the specific quality of tension that changed when someone became aware they were being watched by a person whose opinion of them mattered.

The gun stayed up.

But his wings folded. Not fully. But partially.

Bás Eagla took this as the opening it was.

"We are not here to surveil you. We are not here to enforce anything. The check-in protocol exists as a mutual safety measure for individuals who operate in environments where going dark for an extended period without prior notice can indicate an emergency. Sixteen days with no contact triggered the protocol. We are here only to confirm you are not in a ditch somewhere, and then we will leave."

A long pause.

"I am not in a ditch," Jesús said.

"I can see that."

"I just did not feel like checking in."

"That is noted."

"I do not like being watched."

"That is also noted."

Jesús looked at him for another moment with the expression of someone who had prepared for a much longer fight and was mildly wrong-footed by not getting one. Then he looked at Zephyr again, as though Zephyr was a variable he had not yet categorised and was uncertain about.

"What is that," he said.

Zephyr's mask shifted to something that might have been indignation and might have been amusement. It was a fine line.

"That is my partner," Bás Eagla said. "He is called Zephyr."

"He is very bright."

"He is aware."

Zephyr raised a hand. "Hello," he said, with the mild cheerfulness of someone who had been shot at before and considered it largely a networking opportunity.

Jesús stared at him for another beat. Then, finally, the Chiappa went back to his hip.

He did not relax, exactly. Relaxing did not appear to be something Jesús did as a default state. But the specific charge went out of the air, the kind of charge

that precedes impact, and what replaced it was something more like a very guarded tolerance.

He looked past them to his mother, checking her over in the quick, practiced way of someone who had been doing that particular check for a long time.

She nodded once. She was fine.

He looked back at Bás Eagla.

"Everything is fine," he said. "I am fine. Tell them I am fine and that the next time they want to check up on me they can send a message first instead of sending two people to stand outside my mother's door."

"I will include that in the report."

"Good."

Another pause, shorter this time.

"Are we done?" Jesús asked.

"We are done," Bás Eagla said.

He turned. Zephyr fell into step beside him. They walked back down the passage toward the main lane, and behind them Bás Eagla heard, without turning around, the quiet sound of Jesús crossing to his mother, and her voice, low and even, saying something he filtered out because it was not his to hear.

The vehicle was where they had left it.

They got in. The driver, a local ISP contact who had been waiting without complaint, pulled away from the curb and began navigating back toward the airstrip.

Zephyr was quiet for about thirty seconds, which was approaching his upper limit.

"He pointed a shotgun at us," he said.

"A modified revolver chambered for shotgun shells," Bás Eagla said.

"Technically distinct."

"He pointed it at us."

"Yes."

"And you think that went well."

Bás Eagla considered this with the seriousness the question deserved.

"I think it went as well as it was going to go," he said. "He is alive, unharmed, and not in any apparent danger. He dislikes institutional observation and communicated this clearly. The situation is exactly what the file suggested it would be and nothing more concerning than that."

Zephyr thought about this.

"The wings were cool," he said.

"You mentioned something to that effect on the plane."

"I am reiterating it now that I have seen them in person. One black, one gold. That is genuinely cool. Objectively."

Bás Eagla did not disagree. He looked out the window at the city moving past and thought, briefly and without intending to, about the photograph on the worktable. The young man with his face turned away. The woman standing in front of things.

He put the thought away and picked up the second dossier from the folder.

"New York," he said.

Zephyr settled into his seat.

"Read it out," he said.

Bás Eagla opened the file.

Chapter Three

IRON HEART

Bás Eagla read from the New York file somewhere over the Caribbean, and the file was longer than the previous one, which meant the flight was almost pleasant.

"Subject: Tyrell Mason. Known as Iron Heart. Birthday, June thirtieth. Gender, male. Race classification, human with supernatural endurance and strength enhancements. Current residence, a small apartment in Brooklyn, shared with his younger brother."

Zephyr had his feet up. The jet's interior did not technically have room for this in the way he was doing it, but Zephyr's relationship with available space was creative and generally optimistic.

"Physical profile. Five feet ten, lean and muscular build. Skin described as dark brown with significant scarring distributed across the body from sustained combat history. Shaved head. Trimmed goatee. A scar across the left eyebrow from an early fight. Eyes described as deep, intense brown. Outside of combat, typically found in hoodies and joggers."

"He sounds like someone you would not want to run into in a bad mood," Zephyr said.

"Most people we check on sound like that."

"Fair."

"Background. Mason grew up in Brooklyn, raised by his grandmother after his parents became unavailable to him. The grandmother, name recorded as Mama Lu, is cited as the primary influence on his values. He began boxing at fifteen in a local gym, progressed through underground circuits and into professional leagues. At an unspecified point he defended his younger brother from a gang confrontation, and this drew the attention of an organisation

called the Augur Council, who offered him enhancements in exchange for service against supernatural threats. He accepted."

"The Augur Council," Zephyr repeated.

"Not affiliated with the ISP. Independent operation. The file has a footnote on them but it is not directly relevant."

"What did the enhancement do?"

Bás Eagla turned the page.

"Bones capable of withstanding superhuman force. Musculature capable of extreme feats of power and endurance. Nerve alterations that dull the pain receptors, which allows him to absorb impacts without visible reaction. The cost of the nerve alteration is chronic pain that does not fully subside. The file characterises it as constant." He paused briefly. "He fights through it. The file seems to find this notable enough to mention twice."

Zephyr was quiet for a moment.

"How long has he not checked in?"

"Eleven days."

"And his registered address is in Brooklyn."

"It is."

Zephyr looked out the window at the cloud cover below them, thinking about something else now.

"We are going to be in New York," he said.

"Yes."

"ISP headquarters is in New York."

"It is. The founding base. The organisation's first permanent installation before the network expanded." Bás Eagla closed the folder briefly. "We will

not be visiting it on this trip. We are not here for the building, we are here for Mason."

"I know that." Zephyr paused. "I was thinking about Abraher."

Bás Eagla said nothing, because there was not an immediately useful thing to say.

Abraher Parker was a recruit at Base 45. Twenty-three years old, born in New York, picked up by ISP intake on his birthday of that same year. He was, by any reasonable measure, a young man who had not yet finished becoming whatever he was going to be, which was not unusual for a recruit of his age. What was unusual, or what had become unusual in recent months, was the specific quality of the silence that had settled around him after the events of what the debrief reports called the Plague incident. The details of that assignment were in the files. What was not in the files, because files did not typically capture it, was the way Abraher had looked in the weeks after. The way a person looked when they had done something that could not be undone and had not yet found a way to carry it that did not bend them.

He was from New York. The city they were flying toward. He had not mentioned it when the trip list was circulated. He had not mentioned much of anything lately.

"He will be all right," Zephyr said, which was not a thing Zephyr said often and which therefore meant more when he said it.

"He will need time," Bás Eagla said.

"Yes."

They left it there, which was where it needed to be left, and Bás Eagla opened the folder again.

"Then let us go to Brooklyn," he said.

The address in the file was on a residential block in the southern end of the borough, the kind of street where the buildings were close together and the fire escapes ran down the fronts of them like external scaffolding, and the distance between the windows of one apartment and the next was not quite enough to feel private. It was mid-afternoon when they arrived, the light flat and grey in the way New York light went grey in the autumn, the kind of sky that had not decided whether it was going to rain and was leaving the question open.

Zephyr looked at the building.

"The file said Brooklyn," he said.

"The file said Brooklyn. The ISP contact who arranged the car said the address had been updated in the system after Mason moved. The updated address is in the Bronx." Bás Eagla looked at the building. "We are in the Bronx."

"Right." Zephyr looked up and down the street. "It is a nice street."

This was generous but not entirely inaccurate. The street was functional and lived-in, which were not bad things to be. What it was less, at present, was indifferent to them. Several individuals on the far corner had been watching the car pull up with the specific quality of attention that was not curiosity but assessment, the kind of look that calculated variables quickly and arrived at conclusions before anything had been said.

Bás Eagla was aware of them through The Mind before he stepped out of the car. He was aware of seven people within the immediate vicinity whose collective posture had shifted at the arrival of the vehicle, aware of two more further up the block who were now paying attention where before they had not been, aware of the general texture of the neighbourhood at this time of day, which was the texture of a place that knew its own and noticed what did not fit.

A very tall figure in a shifting neon bodysuit did not fit.

Bás Eagla himself was not exactly unremarkable, but he moved quietly and he moved like someone who was not looking for anything, which helped. Zephyr moved like someone who had arrived and intended for people to know about it, which was simply how Zephyr moved and was not something that changed based on context.

They crossed to the building entrance. Nobody approached them. Nobody said anything. But the watching did not stop, and Bás Eagla noted it and filed it and kept walking.

The apartment was on the third floor. The elevator was not working, which Zephyr accepted with equanimity, and the stairwell was narrow and smelled of cooking and something else underneath it that was more difficult to name. They reached the third floor and found the door.

Bás Eagla knocked.

There was a pause that was a few seconds too long to be nothing, the particular kind of pause that meant someone on the other side was deciding.

"Who is it?" The voice was young. Younger than the file. The file was for Tyrell. This would be the brother.

"We are looking for Tyrell Mason," Bás Eagla said. "We are not from the neighbourhood. We are not affiliated with anyone in the neighbourhood. My name is Bás Eagla and I am an agent with an organisation called the International Security Program. We have your brother registered as an individual we check in with, and he has not made contact in eleven days. We are here to find out if he is all right."

Another pause. Longer.

The door opened on a chain. A face appeared in the gap, young, maybe sixteen, with Tyrell's same intense eyes set in a face that had not yet settled into whatever it was going to become. He looked at Bás Eagla. He looked further up at Zephyr, and his expression did something complicated.

"What is that," he said.

"My partner," Bás Eagla said. "His name is Zephyr. He is harmless."

"Debatable," Zephyr said pleasantly.

The boy stared at Zephyr for another moment. Then the chain came off and the door opened.

His name was Malcolm and he was frightened in the specific way of someone who had been holding it together for several days and was running low on the resources required to keep doing that. The apartment was small and clean in the careful way of people who took care of what they had. There were photographs on the wall near the kitchen. Tyrell in a boxing gym, wraps on his hands, not looking at the camera. An older woman with a broad, settled smile who could only be Mama Lu. Malcolm at what looked like a school event, younger, grinning with the uncomplicated happiness of a kid who did not yet know what the next few years would contain.

Malcolm sat on the couch and told them what he knew, which was not much, and what he suspected, which was more.

Tyrell had been gone for eleven days. He had left the apartment early on a Tuesday morning, which was his usual time for running the neighbourhood circuit he had done every day for years. He had not come back. His phone went to voicemail after the first day and had not changed since. Malcolm had asked around, because Malcolm knew the neighbourhood and knew how to ask, and what he had gotten in return was the particular quality of non-answer that meant people knew something and had decided not to say it.

"He is not dead," Malcolm said. He said it with a flatness that meant he had argued himself to this conclusion more than once and was not entirely sure of it. "If something had happened to him somebody would have told me. People around here, they look out for each other when it matters. If he was gone-gone somebody would have said."

"I agree with that assessment," Bás Eagla said.

Malcolm looked at him. "You do?"

"Yes." Bás Eagla did not elaborate on the reasons for this, which included the fact that The Mind had spent the last several minutes reaching outward through the building and the block and had found no one in the immediate vicinity who was carrying grief of that particular texture, and grief had a very specific quality that was different from fear or from the silence of people who knew something. What he found instead was the second kind, distributed through certain individuals on this block and the next one over. "Someone in this neighbourhood knows where he is. We are going to find out who."

Malcolm looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at Zephyr, who had not sat down because there was not a surface in the apartment adequate for that purpose, and was standing near the window with his mask on something that looked like careful attentiveness.

"All right," Malcolm said. "What do you need from me?"

"Nothing," Bás Eagla said. "Stay here. Lock the door after we leave."

The street was the same as it had been but the afternoon had moved on and the light had gotten flatter. Bás Eagla stood on the pavement outside the building and extended his awareness and did what he did, which was listen in the way that had nothing to do with ears.

It took a few minutes. The Mind was not a targeted instrument; it was a wide one, and wide meant sifting, and sifting meant patience, which Bás Eagla had in abundance. He moved through the texture of the block, the weight of individual days, the specific emotional frequencies of people going about their afternoons, and he found what he was looking for in two places at once: a man sitting in a car three buildings down whose knowledge of where Tyrell Mason was had the quality of something he was actively trying not to think about, and a woman on the second floor of the building across the street whose awareness of the same fact was quieter and older, more settled, the kind of knowledge

you carried when you had known something for days and had decided you were not going to be the one to say it.

He did not need to read either of them further than that.

"He is being held," Bás Eagla said.

Zephyr, who had been standing beside him watching the street with the particular quality of alertness he maintained when he was in environments that warranted it, turned to look at him.

"Held."

"Against his will. By a group operating out of somewhere in this neighbourhood. The people who know are not going to talk to us directly." He paused, extending slightly further, tracing the texture of the knowledge outward to where it was thinner and more specific. It resolved, after a moment, into a direction. "There is a building two streets east. I cannot tell you what is inside it from here. But it is where everyone's awareness points when they are trying not to think about Tyrell Mason."

Zephyr's mask shifted into something focused.

"Then we go two streets east," he said.

The building was a commercial property that had stopped being commercial long enough ago that the original signage was unreadable, the lettering faded to outlines on the facade. The ground floor windows were covered from the inside. The door was metal, newer than the building around it, with a heavy lock that had not been there when the building was originally constructed.

There were two men outside it who were not standing outside it for any obvious reason.

Bás Eagla assessed them from across the street. Through The Mind he assessed the building itself, the weight of presences inside it, more than he had expected, at least a dozen, distributed across two floors. And on the lower

floor, separated from the others by the quality of what he felt from him, a single person whose state was the very specific state of someone who had been enduring something for a long time and had settled into a place underneath anger and underneath pain where there was only the waiting.

That would be Mason.

"Twelve inside," Bás Eagla said quietly. "Possibly more on the upper floor. Two outside. Mason is on the ground floor at the back."

Zephyr cracked his knuckles, which produced a sound like a small structural event.

"I will take the door," he said.

"I will take the inside."

They crossed the street.

The two men outside noticed them at about the fifteen-metre mark, which was when Zephyr's bodysuit cycled through a particularly bright sequence of colours that caught the light from the streetlamp and made itself impossible to ignore. Both men straightened and one of them said something that was not a greeting, and then Zephyr covered the remaining distance in a time that made the statement feel retrospectively unnecessary, and the conversation ended before it fully began.

Bás Eagla was already shadow by then, flat against the ground and moving under the door, through the gap at the base of the frame, into the building before the sound from outside had fully registered inside.

The interior was a single large space that had been organised into something functional by people who were not interested in comfort. There were folding chairs, tables, equipment that did not need to be described in detail. There were nine men visible from floor level, several of whom were already getting up because the noise from outside had reached them, and getting up meant reaching for things, and reaching for things meant the situation was not going to resolve quietly.

Bás Eagla emerged from the shadow at the centre of the room.

What happened next was not long in duration. The Nightmare ability was not something he used often, because it was a profound thing to do to a person, to reach into the processing of their mind and restructure what they were receiving from the world. But it was fast, and it was non-lethal, and twelve men in an enclosed space who all simultaneously received an extremely specific and personal version of something they feared deeply were not, for the following several minutes, a functional opposing force.

Zephyr came through the door while it was still in progress. He assessed the room in the way Zephyr assessed rooms, which was comprehensive and immediate, identified the three men who were managing to resist the effect through sheer force of will or proximity to the wall or simple stubbornness, and handled the three in the efficient and direct manner that was his preferred approach to problems of this nature.

The room settled.

Bás Eagla walked to the back.

The rear room was smaller and had a single light source, a bare bulb, that threw hard shadows. Tyrell Mason was in the corner, his wrists bound behind him to a pipe set into the wall, and he looked exactly like the file and also like someone who had been held against his will for eleven days and had spent most of that time deciding what he was going to do when the opportunity presented itself.

His head came up when Bás Eagla entered.

His eyes were exactly as described: deep, intense brown, with a quality that did not change based on context.

"I am going to get you out of here," Bás Eagla said.

Mason looked at him. He looked at the skull mask and the dark robe and the pitch-black hands, and his expression was the expression of a man who had

learned very early that the category of person who came to get you out of somewhere was not automatically the same as the category of person you wanted to be released to.

"Who sent you," he said. His voice was exactly what the file suggested it would be: not loud, very certain.

"The ISP. You have been in our system since your intake with the Augur Council. You missed eleven days of check-in protocol and we were sent to locate you." Bás Eagla crouched and looked at the binding. Standard restraints, not designed for someone with Mason's augmented bone structure, which explained why they were still intact: Mason could have broken them, in all likelihood, but breaking them would have been loud and the room behind him had contained twelve armed people. He had been waiting for a better moment. "The room outside has been handled."

A pause.

"By who?" Mason said.

"My partner is approximately six feet seven and glows. He is also currently standing in the doorway behind me, if you would like confirmation."

Mason looked past Bás Eagla to the doorway. Zephyr raised a hand. His mask displayed something that was attempting to communicate reassurance.

Mason looked at Zephyr for a long moment.

"All right," he said.

Bás Eagla put his hand on the pipe fitting, let the shadow work into the bolt, and the binding came loose. Mason's arms came forward and he rolled his shoulders once, with the controlled movement of someone taking inventory of their body before committing to using it, and stood.

He was five feet ten and he filled the room differently than his height suggested he should. The scars were visible on his arms and his hands. The scar across the left eyebrow caught the light from the bare bulb.

He walked to the door.

He stepped into the main room.

He looked at the state of the main room, which was not a state that invited lingering commentary.

Then he looked at Bás Eagla, who had followed him out, and at Zephyr, and his expression did the thing that expressions did when something that was almost a conclusion became actually a conclusion.

He threw a punch at Bás Eagla.

It was not a slow punch. It was a fast punch from a man whose reflexes had been honed to near perfection and whose augmented strength meant that the air moved ahead of it before it arrived. Bás Eagla was not there when it arrived, which was simply what happened when you had Umbral Intangibility as an available option and the situational awareness to use it, and Mason's fist passed through the space where Bás Eagla's head had been and connected with nothing, which was disorienting enough that the follow-through did not come immediately.

Zephyr stepped between them.

This was largely a matter of geometry. Zephyr was large enough that stepping between two other people in an indoor space constituted a significant change in the environment for everyone involved, and the combined effect of his size and the fact that the bodysuit had just cycled to a very bright sequence gave Mason approximately half a second of recalibration that he used, because Mason was a combat genius and recalibration was something combat geniuses did quickly, to assess.

"We are not with them," Zephyr said. He kept his voice level, which was a specific choice. "We came in from outside. We are ISP agents. We found you because we tracked where the people in this neighbourhood were trying not to look." He paused. "Your brother is at the apartment. He is fine. He is the one who confirmed you were missing."

Mason looked at him.

Something in the quality of his focus changed. Not much. But it changed.

"Malcolm," he said.

"Yes."

Mason looked at Bás Eagla, who had stepped out of intangibility and was standing where he had been standing, patient and unhurried.

"You went to him first," Mason said.

"The apartment was the registered address."

"Is he all right."

"He is frightened for you," Bás Eagla said. "Otherwise he is fine. He was the one who told us people in the neighbourhood were not saying what they knew, which narrowed the search considerably."

Mason stood with this for a moment. The chronic pain the file described was not visible on his face because Mason did not let it be visible on his face, but Bás Eagla could feel it through The Mind as a constant low undertone, the kind of thing that was always there and that the person carrying it had long since stopped expecting to go away.

"ISP," Mason said. He said it the way Jesús had said it, with the weight of someone who had opinions about organisations, and the opinions were not entirely warm. But there was a different quality to it than Jesús had had. Jesús's flatness was about not being watched. Mason's was the flatness of a man who had already dealt with one organisation and was taking the measure of a second.

"Yes," Bás Eagla said.

"And you just check in. That is all."

"That is the purpose of this particular visit, yes."

Another pause. Mason looked around the room one more time, taking in what had been done to it and what that implied about the people who had done it. His expression was not impressed or grateful. It was the expression of a man receiving data and adding it to a set of data he was already working with.

"All right," he said. "Take me back to Malcolm."

The walk back was two streets and took about four minutes. Bás Eagla walked on one side and Zephyr on the other and Mason walked between them with the upright, controlled movement of someone who was in persistent pain and refused to let it change the way he moved through the world.

Zephyr, after about a minute and a half of silence that he found more challenging than Bás Eagla did, said: "Your file says you broke into professional boxing from the underground circuits."

Mason looked at him.

"That is in a file somewhere," Mason said.

"Your ISP intake profile."

"Right." He was quiet for a moment. "Yeah. I did."

"Did you like it? The professional side?"

A pause that had something thoughtful at the bottom of it.

"Parts of it," Mason said. "The parts that were about the fight. Not the parts that were about everything else."

Zephyr nodded, with the air of someone who found this answer completely comprehensible.

They reached the building. Bás Eagla pressed the buzzer for the apartment.

The intercom clicked immediately, which meant Malcolm had been sitting next to it.

"It is us," Bás Eagla said. "We have your brother."

The door buzzed open before he finished the sentence.

They heard Malcolm on the stairs before they saw him, taking them at a pace that had nothing to do with dignity and everything to do with getting to the bottom of them as fast as possible, and then he was there, and Mason caught him by the back of the neck and pulled him in the way older brothers do when they have been gone somewhere they did not choose to go and come back to something they were worried about, and Bás Eagla and Zephyr both found something else in the stairwell to direct their attention toward for a moment.

When Mason looked up again, his face had returned to the default expression, the one that did not show things. But his hand was still on his brother's shoulder.

"How long are you going to be checking in?" Mason asked.

"That depends on factors above my level of authority," Bás Eagla said. "For now, monthly contact is the requirement. If you find it easier to initiate the contact yourself rather than wait for the scheduled prompt, that option is available."

Mason looked at him for a moment.

"Fine," he said. "I will call."

"Good."

They left Mason and Malcolm in the stairwell and went back out to the street. The men on the corner were still there, but the quality of their attention had shifted from assessment to something closer to neutral, which was the closest this particular street came to approval.

Zephyr's bodysuit cycled through a cheerful sequence of colours as they walked to the car, and at least two of the men on the corner watched it with an expression that was not entirely hostile.

Small progress, Bás Eagla thought, and got in the car.

Back at the airstrip, while the jet was being prepared, Zephyr sat on a bench in the small terminal and stretched his legs out to a length that made the bench look provisional.

"He punched at you," he said.

"He did."

"And you just went intangible."

"It seemed like the efficient response."

Zephyr thought about this. "What if I had not stepped in after?"

"I would have explained the situation."

"While he was still punching at you?"

"People are often more receptive to information after they have tested whether the situation is physical and found it inconclusive."

Zephyr stared at him.

"That is," he said, slowly, "a very specific way to look at getting punched."

"I was not punched. I was intangible."

Zephyr shook his head, which his mask accompanied with an expression of resigned amusement, and looked out the terminal window at the city beyond the perimeter fence. New York from the outside, from the distance of a departure. The skyline was doing what skylines did at dusk, turning the buildings into silhouettes and making the whole thing look more deliberate than it was.

"Abraher was born here," Zephyr said, not to anyone in particular.

Bás Eagla looked at the skyline too.

"Yes," he said.

Neither of them said anything else about it. There was not anything else that needed saying, and the jet was ready, and Scotland was a long way from here, and they had five more stops to make.

Bás Eagla picked up the next folder.

Chapter Four

THE BEWITCHING SPECTER

The flight from New York to Scotland was long enough that Bás Eagla read the full file twice and Zephyr fell asleep for three hours sitting almost entirely upright, which should not have been possible given the dimensions of the seat, and yet.

When Zephyr woke up, Bás Eagla was still reading.

"You have been awake this whole time," Zephyr said.

"Yes."

"Do you sleep?"

"On occasion."

Zephyr looked at him for a moment, then decided not to pursue this line of inquiry and looked out the window instead. Below them, the Atlantic had given way to coastline, and the coastline had given way to something green and grey and uneven that could only be Scotland.

"Read it out," he said.

Bás Eagla set down the second read-through and picked up the file.

"Subject: Lady Morganna. Known as the Bewitching Specter. Gender, female. Race classification, ethereal witch. Last descendant of a noble family with documented supernatural ties. Current residence listed as nomadic, though the file notes she returns frequently to the family estate."

"A witch," Zephyr said, with the tone of someone noting an interesting variable.

"An ethereal witch. The distinction appears to be meaningful."

"What does she look like?"

Bás Eagla turned the page. "Physical profile. Five foot six. Pale skin described as porcelain-like and somewhat translucent in certain light. Long pastel pink hair. Eyes with wide, dark pupils set in pale grey irises, noted as hypnotic. Always seen in Victorian-inspired gothic attire: striped dress, ornate lace, large black hat adorned with roses and occult symbols. Carries a polished, twisted cane with a crystal handle that glows when she channels her magic." He paused. "The file also notes two ghostly companions who accompany her at all times."

"Ghostly companions."

"Named Wisp and Glum. Wisp is described as mischievous and prone to causing light-hearted chaos. Glum is more solemn and functions primarily as a warning system for approaching danger. Both have masks that change expression based on their mood."

A pause.

Zephyr's mask shifted to an expression of what could only be described as professional solidarity.

"Two of them have masks," he said.

"Yes."

"And they float."

"According to the file."

"I feel," Zephyr said, with some gravity, "that I am going to get along with this person."

Bás Eagla continued reading. "Personality. Playful, macabre, sly wit, sharp mind. Uses charm to manipulate situations to her advantage. Prone to dark humour and mischievous laughter, particularly when she startles others. Described as deeply protective of Wisp and Glum, treating them as family. Maintains an air of mystery and unpredictability that keeps people at a distance." He lowered the file briefly. "The intake notes include a handwritten

addendum from the field agent who made initial contact. It reads: she let a spirit pick my pocket during the interview. I only noticed when I got back to the car. She had replaced my identification card with a small card that said 'better luck next time.'"

Zephyr made a sound that was not quite a laugh but was structurally adjacent to one.

"How long since contact?" he asked.

"Twenty-two days. The longest of anyone on this list."

"And she lives in a haunted mansion."

"In a supernatural forest. In Scotland. Yes."

"Wonderful," Zephyr said, and meant it.

Bás Eagla closed the file.

"Also," Zephyr said, looking out at the approaching coastline with an expression his mask rendered as cheerful anticipation, "you are almost home."

Bás Eagla looked at him.

"I am Irish," he said.

"Close enough."

"It is emphatically not close enough."

"Same island group."

"Scotland and Ireland are not the same island."

"British Isles."

"That," Bás Eagla said, with the deliberate calm of a man choosing his battles, "is a geographic designation, not a cultural one, and I would encourage you not to say it to anyone we meet on the ground."

Zephyr's mask displayed the expression of someone filing this advice away without necessarily committing to following it. He looked back out the window.

"Still. Green hills. Fog. You must feel something."

Bás Eagla looked out his own window at the green hills and the fog.

"I feel that we are going to be late if the ground vehicle is not where the contact said it would be," he said, and picked up the folder.

Ravensmere was not on any map that the ISP's ground contact had been able to locate with confidence, which the contact had communicated in the kind of carefully worded message that meant they had tried and had decided that trying further was not worth what it cost them. What they did have was a general direction and a road that became a track and then became a suggestion, and beyond the suggestion there was forest.

The forest was the kind that did not feel like it was simply trees. It was the kind that felt like it had been there longer than the roads around it and had opinions about that fact. The light that reached the ground was grey and particulate, fog sitting low between the trunks, and the sounds were the sounds of a place that was not especially interested in being navigated.

"This is very atmospheric," Zephyr said, from the passenger seat of the ground vehicle.

The driver, who was a local ISP contact and had taken the job because he had been told it was a standard welfare check and had not been told about the forest, said nothing. He was gripping the wheel with the focused attention of someone pretending he was not unnerved.

Bás Eagla, in the back, was extending The Mind outward through the tree line and finding it an interesting exercise. There were presences in this forest that did not read the way living things read. They were there, they had weight, they had something that functioned like awareness, but the texture of it was

different. Old and lateral, like paper laid flat rather than standing upright. He noted them and did not push further.

"There," he said.

Through the trees, at the end of what might charitably be called a driveway, the mansion resolved out of the fog the way things in fog always did: too suddenly, too close, fully formed as if it had simply decided to be visible. It was large in the way that old houses were large, the kind of large that came from being added to over generations rather than planned, with towers that did not quite match and windows that caught no light and a front door that was painted black and had a knocker shaped like something Bás Eagla chose not to identify more specifically.

"Excellent," Zephyr said.

The driver stopped the car at the gate and communicated clearly, without saying a word, that he intended to remain there.

They got out.

The front door opened before they knocked.

Not because anyone was on the other side of it. It simply opened, inward, at its own pace, and the hallway beyond it was dark in the way of a house where the lights were a suggestion rather than a given. Candles, somewhere further in, gave the air a faint amber quality that did not reach the ceiling.

Bás Eagla stepped inside. Zephyr followed, ducking slightly for the doorframe, and the door closed behind them of its own accord.

"Cheerful," Zephyr said.

Through The Mind, Bás Eagla was aware of several presences in the house. The same lateral, old texture as the forest, distributed through the walls and the floors like a network. And somewhere deeper in, two smaller presences

with a more active quality, quicker, more present, with something that felt almost like anticipation.

That would be Wisp and Glum.

He was about to say something to Zephyr about this when the hallway branched, and one branch went left and one went right, and the candelabra in the left branch extinguished itself, and the ones in the right branch brightened, and Zephyr, with the absolute confidence of someone who trusted theatrical prompts, said "This way" and went right.

"Zephyr," Bás Eagla said.

But Zephyr had already turned the corner.

Bás Eagla looked at the left branch, which was now entirely dark, and at the right branch, where the candlelight was already beginning to diminish around the corner Zephyr had taken. He felt, through The Mind, the small quick presence of Wisp somewhere near the ceiling at the end of the left corridor, very still, in the manner of something that was waiting to see what happened next.

He went left.

The left corridor had portraits.

This was not unusual for a house of this age and type. What was unusual was that the portraits were watching him, and not in the metaphorical sense in which people described old paintings as watchful. The eyes in the portraits were actually tracking him as he walked, slowly, without blinking, with the composed and faintly judgmental attention of people who had been sitting in frames for a very long time and had developed opinions.

Bás Eagla walked past them at the same pace he walked everywhere.

One portrait, a severe-looking woman in what appeared to be seventeenth century dress, leaned fractionally forward as he passed, as if to get a better

look. Bás Eagla paused in front of her. They regarded each other for a moment. Then he continued walking, and he heard, behind him, a sound that might have been a harrumph from inside a frame, or might have been the house settling.

At the end of the corridor, a door opened onto a staircase that went up.

He took the stairs.

At the top, another corridor, longer, with a window at the far end that looked out onto fog and nothing else. There was a chandelier, unlit, and as he walked beneath it, every crystal on it began to chime softly, each at a slightly different pitch, producing something that was not quite music but was close enough to be unsettling. A cold draft arrived from nowhere, passed through him, and left.

He paused.

Then, from very close to his left ear, a small voice said: "Boo."

It was not a loud sound. It was a small, self-satisfied sound, the boo of a presence that understood the concept and was applying it with precision rather than volume. Bás Eagla turned his head.

Wisp was approximately the size of a large grapefruit and was currently hovering at ear height, its mask displaying the widest possible grin. It tilted slightly to one side, in the way of something that had been hoping for a reaction and was recalibrating.

Bás Eagla looked at it.

"Hello," he said.

Wisp's grin flickered. The mask shifted through two expressions rapidly before settling back on the grin, this time with something that looked a little more uncertain around the edges. It had, clearly, been expecting a different response.

"I am looking for Lady Morganna," Bás Eagla said. "If you are able to lead me to her, I would appreciate it. If you are not inclined to do that, I will find her by other means, and I want to be clear that I do not say that as a threat. I simply have a passive sensory ability that covers this entire building, and it is only a matter of time."

Wisp stared at him.

Then it turned, very slowly, and drifted down the corridor.

Bás Eagla followed.

Zephyr's experience of the right corridor was different.

It started conventionally enough: the corridor, the candlelight, a turn that led to another corridor, and then a parlour, and then a door that had been open when he looked at it from ten feet away and was closed when he reached it, which he noticed but did not find especially troubling. He tried the handle. It was locked. He tried it with somewhat more persuasion. It was not locked anymore.

The room beyond was a library, which was a perfectly reasonable thing for a room to be, and Zephyr spent a moment appreciating the volume of books before something dropped from the ceiling and landed on his head.

He reached up. His hand closed around something round and soft and approximately the size of a grapefruit, and he brought it down in front of his face and found himself looking at Glum, who had its mask set to the expression of something that had not anticipated being caught and was now assessing whether this was a dignified position to be in.

"Hello," Zephyr said.

Glum looked at him. Then it looked at his mask. Then it looked back at him with the expression of something encountering a professional peer under unexpected circumstances.

"We have similar faces," Zephyr said, gesturing between his mask and Glum's. "I think that makes us colleagues."

Glum's expression shifted, slowly, to something that was not entirely opposed to this framing.

Zephyr set it down, gently, in the air, where it hovered. He looked around the library. "Lady Morganna," he said. "Any chance you could point me toward her?"

Glum looked at him for a long moment, with the solemn deliberation of something that weighed its decisions carefully. Then it drifted, slowly, toward the far wall, where a bookcase sat that was, on closer inspection, not entirely flush with the wall behind it.

Zephyr looked at it. "A secret door," he said, with genuine appreciation. "In a haunted mansion. Obviously."

He pushed the bookcase, which swung inward on a hinge, and went through.

They found each other in a room that might have been a study or might have been a laboratory or might have been both, on the evidence of the desk covered in papers and the table covered in things that were not papers. There were jars along one wall whose contents Bás Eagla catalogued briefly and did not dwell on. There was a fireplace with a fire in it that burned the wrong colour, a deep blue-green that lit the room with the quality of light that came through water. The walls were covered in diagrams and symbols that intersected each other in ways that implied a system, though not one Bás Eagla had encountered previously.

Zephyr came through a door in the bookcase at the same moment Bás Eagla came through the door in the opposite wall, both of them arriving from different directions, both of them with a small floating entity trailing behind them.

They looked at each other.

Wisp and Glum looked at each other.

"Secret passage?" Zephyr asked.

"Corridor of portraits, then stairs, then a chandelier," Bás Eagla said.

"Library. Glum dropped on my head."

"Wisp said boo."

"Did it work?"

"No."

Zephyr looked at Wisp. "Better luck next time."

Wisp's mask cycled to an expression that looked like genuine consideration of this feedback.

Then the laughter started.

It came from the far end of the room, from the high-backed chair beside the fireplace that Bás Eagla had registered as occupied but had not yet turned to address, and it was the laughter of someone who had been watching the last thirty seconds unfold with considerable private enjoyment and could no longer maintain the pretence of not having done so. It was bright and slightly unhinged and carried the specific musical quality of a person who laughed exactly as much as they wanted to and did not moderate it for social context.

Lady Morganna unfolded from the chair.

She was exactly the file and also more than the file, in the way that descriptions always failed the specific quality of a person's presence. The hat was real and large and the roses on it were real roses, somehow, dark and perfect without wilting. The pink hair fell in waves that caught the blue-green firelight and turned colours that pink hair should not have turned. The cane rested against the arm of the chair, its crystal handle pulsing faintly, and Wisp and Glum both drifted immediately to her, Wisp nuzzling against her

shoulder, Glum taking up a station slightly behind and to the left with the proprietary air of a bodyguard.

Her eyes were exactly as described. Wide, dark-pupilled, pale-irised. They moved between Bás Eagla and Zephyr with an assessment that was also an amusement.

"Well," she said, and her voice had the quality of someone who enjoyed the sounds words made, "the portraits said you came in without being invited. Most people scream at the portraits."

"I have encountered the sensation of being observed before," Bás Eagla said.

She looked at him with her head tilted slightly. "You are the interesting one," she said, not unkindly, in the manner of someone making a taxonomic observation. Then she looked at Zephyr. "And you." A pause. "What are you?"

"I have been asking myself that for some time," Zephyr said pleasantly. "I have not arrived at a satisfying answer."

This produced another burst of laughter, shorter, more surprised, as if the answer had been better than she was expecting. She moved to the desk and perched on its edge with the ease of someone entirely at home in a room that was objectively trying to be unsettling.

"ISP," she said, and unlike Jesús and unlike Mason, the word on her lips was not flat or wary. It was something closer to theatrical disdain, the kind that carried a smile inside it. "They sent two of you. I am either very missed or very suspected."

"Twenty-two days without contact," Bás Eagla said. "The protocol requires a welfare check above a threshold. You crossed it."

"I have been busy."

"The protocol does not account for busy."

"Most protocols do not account for much, in my experience." She turned the cane in her hands, slowly, the crystal end catching the fire. "What is it you

actually want from me, ISP agent? You want to know I am alive. You want me to promise I will tap the little button on the little schedule." She gestured vaguely. "Very well. I promise."

"You are going to break that promise," Zephyr said.

She looked at him with genuine delight. "Almost certainly," she agreed. "But I will break it with such charm that by the time you notice, you will have already forgiven me."

Bás Eagla regarded her for a moment. Through The Mind he could feel the mansion around them, all of it, the weight of the spirits in the walls, the specific relationship between Morganna and Wisp and Glum, which was not ownership and was not employment but was something older and more mutual than either. She was not lying about being fine. She was not lying about promising. She was simply the kind of person for whom promises were a starting position in a negotiation rather than a conclusion.

"I will note in the report that contact was established and that you are in good health," he said.

"How dull of you."

"I will also note that the estate's spirits appear functional and the two named companions are present and in good spirits, if you will excuse the phrase."

She pointed at him. "That," she said, "was almost a joke. I did not expect that from you."

"I did not intend it as one."

"Even better." She stood from the desk, with the particular movement of someone who made standing up look like a decision rather than a reflex. "You will want to leave before dark. The forest has different opinions about people at night."

"Different from what?" Zephyr asked.

"From its current opinions, which are only mildly complicated." She smiled, and the smile had the quality of someone who had lived in a place long enough to find its most dangerous features reassuring. "I am fine. I am alive. I will check in. Probably. The house enjoyed your visit, I think. The portraits rarely get anyone who walks past without flinching."

Bás Eagla glanced at Wisp, who was hovering near his shoulder with an expression on its mask that had settled, over the course of the visit, into something that was less the grin of a prankster and more the alert curiosity of a creature that had found something new and was cataloguing it.

"Thank you for your time," Bás Eagla said.

"Thank you for the entertainment." She looked at Zephyr. "Come back sometime when you are not on a schedule. We could have a much more interesting conversation."

"I would genuinely enjoy that," Zephyr said, and meant it.

Wisp led them back through the house, which took a considerably more direct route than either of them had taken on the way in, as if the house itself had decided there was no further mileage in complicating things. The front door opened for them. The fog outside was thicker than it had been, but the path to the gate was visible, lit faintly, as if the grounds were seeing them out.

The driver had remained at the gate. He had the look of a man who had spent time alone in a car in a supernatural forest and had arrived at a personal decision about how often he intended to do this in the future.

They were in the car and back on the track before Zephyr said anything.

"Glum dropped on my head," he said, "and I held a ghost, and I found a secret passage behind a bookcase."

"Yes."

"This was the best stop so far."

Bás Eagla looked out the window at the forest moving past, the fog between the trees, the grey light settling into something darker as the afternoon declined.

"She is not going to check in," he said.

"No," Zephyr agreed. "She is absolutely not."

"We will be back in three weeks."

"I hope Glum drops on my head again." Zephyr settled into his seat. "Wisp said boo to you."

"It did."

"And nothing happened."

"I was aware it was there before it said anything."

Zephyr shook his head slowly. "You cannot let small haunted entities have their moment. This is a character flaw."

"It tried. I acknowledged it. I directed it toward useful action. That seems like a reasonable outcome for everyone."

"The outcome it wanted," Zephyr said, "was for you to scream."

"I am aware."

"And you denied it that."

"I did."

"Heartless," Zephyr said, but his mask was the expression of someone deeply entertained, and outside the window the forest gave way to open road and the fog thinned and the sky to the west still had a thin line of light at its base, pale gold and very far away, and Bás Eagla looked at it for a moment before looking back at the next folder on the stack.

"Sweden," he said.

Zephyr picked up the file. "I will read this one," he said.

Bás Eagla looked at him.

"You can read," Zephyr said, with the mild indignation of someone whose literacy was being silently questioned, "I can also read. I am going to read the file."

"I was not questioning whether you could read."

"You had a face."

"I always have this face."

Zephyr opened the file. Bás Eagla looked back out the window and said nothing, which was the closest he generally came to conceding a point.

Chapter Five

THE WILDSHIELD

Zephyr read the file.

He read it with the focused attention of someone who had made a point and intended to follow through on it, holding the folder at an angle that accommodated the cabin lighting and turning the pages with a deliberateness that communicated he was doing this properly and not just looking at the pictures.

Bás Eagla watched him for a moment and then looked out the window.

"Subject," Zephyr said, "Goroth. Known as the Wildshield. Birthday listed as born under the Storm Moon, which the file's intake agent has followed up with the note that they were unable to convert this to a conventional calendar date and the subject was not forthcoming when asked." He turned the page.

"Gender, male. Race, human, tribal warrior classification. Six feet eight. Bronzed skin, heavy scarring. Horned helm. Runic tattoos across arms and chest. Carries a double-headed spear with a backup bow." He paused. "The file also notes a companion."

"Boulder," Bás Eagla said.

"Boulder," Zephyr confirmed. "A bear. Tawny-furred. Claws described as capable of tearing through armour. One hundred and fifty-five centimetres at the shoulder on all fours, three hundred and forty centimetres on hind legs." He looked up from the file. "Three hundred and forty centimetres."

"Yes."

"That is taller than me."

"Significantly."

Zephyr looked back down at the file and then back up again. "How much taller than me?"

"Approximately seventy centimetres."

Zephyr sat with this information for a moment with the expression of someone recalibrating their sense of scale. Then he continued reading.

"Personality. Fiercely protective. Resilient. Straightforward, focused on survival and strength. Not quick to trust. Prefers actions to words. Silent in most contexts, though described as roaring, and I am quoting directly from the file here, with the vigour of his bear companion in moments of victory." He set the file on his knee. "What does he not check in about?"

"Thirteen days. The file has a note from the intake coordinator suggesting that contact has been inconsistent since the beginning of his registration. Not hostile, simply infrequent."

"Where does he live?"

"The file lists his current residence as roaming. He has a cave in the northern forest territories of Sweden. The local ISP contact has a general location."

Zephyr looked out the window at the darkness below the jet, which was the darkness of the North Sea at night, and then at the darkness ahead of it, which was more darkness.

"A cave," he said.

"A cave."

"In the north of Sweden."

"In the far north of Sweden, yes."

"With a bear."

"With a bear."

Zephyr's mask cycled to an expression that was not easy to read but was in the general territory of anticipatory enthusiasm. He closed the file and set it back on the stack.

"I like this trip," he said.

The local ISP contact was a woman named Astrid who operated out of a small field office in a town that was the last town before the territory became the kind of territory that did not have towns. She met them at the airstrip in a vehicle built for the kind of ground it was going to be crossing, and she communicated, within approximately thirty seconds of meeting them, that she had been briefed on who they were and had decided to be professionally neutral about it.

"The cave is four hours from here," she said, in English that was precise and slightly clipped. "I can get you to within two kilometres. After that the ground is too uneven for the vehicle. You walk."

"That is fine," Bás Eagla said.

She looked at Zephyr. Zephyr's bodysuit was cycling through a slow sequence that in the low grey light of early morning produced colours that had no business being that visible. She looked back at the road.

"The bear has been seen in the area," she said. "If you encounter it without the man present, do not run. Do not make direct eye contact. Make yourself large."

Zephyr looked at her. "I am already large."

"Make yourself larger."

"I am six feet seven."

Astrid drove and said nothing further on the subject, which was a form of communication in itself.

The landscape outside the vehicle changed as they moved north, the flat giving way to the uneven and the uneven giving way to something older and more deliberate, forest with the particular density of forest that had not been managed or accommodated but simply grown, on its own terms, for a very

long time. The light stayed low and lateral, the sun at this latitude and this hour sitting barely above the treeline, painting everything in a blue-grey that was either cold or beautiful depending on your disposition. Bás Eagla found it neither. He found it legible, the kind of landscape that communicated its own rules clearly and expected you to read them.

Through The Mind, he was extending his awareness outward through the trees, reading the texture of the forest. Living things, the continuous hum of a functioning wilderness, birds and smaller animals and something larger moving to the north-east. Something very large. Patient and unhurried, with the specific weight of an animal that had no reason to be afraid of anything in its immediate environment.

"Boulder is north-east of our current position," he said. "Moving slowly. Probably foraging."

Astrid glanced at him in the rearview mirror and said nothing.

"What about Goroeth?" Zephyr asked.

"Further. The same direction, but further. Stationary." He extended slightly more. "The cave, I think. He is resting."

Astrid stopped the vehicle where the track ended, which was where she had said it would end, and wished them luck with the specific brevity of someone who meant it but did not think it was going to be sufficient.

They walked two kilometres through the kind of terrain that did not believe in paths. The ground was cold and uneven, covered in the deep accumulated matter of decades of forest floor, roots and moss and the slow architectural work of fallen trees becoming soil. The air had a quality to it that was not unpleasant, clean in the specific way of places that were a very long distance from everything else.

Zephyr walked through it with the good-natured momentum of someone for whom terrain was largely a suggestion, stepping over things that needed

stepping over and through things that did not present a real obstacle to someone of his dimensions and construction. The bodysuit cycled through muted tones in the forest light, greens and deep blues that were, for once, not entirely out of place.

The cave resolved from the hillside gradually, the entrance a dark gap in the rock face partially screened by undergrowth that had been pushed aside and then pushed back so many times that it had learned to accommodate the passage of something very large. The tracks outside it were fresh.

"Boulder is inside," Bás Eagla said, reading the tracks and also reading The Mind, in which the large patient presence had shifted, perhaps ten minutes ago, from north-east to directly ahead. "Goroth is not. He is somewhere to the west. Still resting."

Zephyr looked at the cave entrance, then at Bás Eagla, then at the cave entrance again.

"We should knock," he said.

"There is no door."

"We should announce ourselves."

"If we announce ourselves to an unsupervised bear," Bás Eagla said, "the outcome is the same regardless of tone."

Zephyr considered this. "Valid," he said, and ducked through the entrance.

The interior of the cave was larger than the entrance suggested, the way caves often were, and it had the lived-in quality of a space that had been inhabited long enough to develop a character. There were pelts along one wall, layered and ordered in a way that implied a system rather than an accumulation. Tools along another wall, maintained in the precise, clean manner of someone who understood that their tools were the difference between surviving and not. A fire pit at the centre, cold now but with the banked quality of something

that would be relit by evening. Bones and remnants from multiple meals, tidily stacked at the far wall.

And Boulder.

Boulder was at the back of the cave, and was considerably more present than any written description of him had managed to convey. He was lying down, which helped with the ceiling clearance, and in that position he occupied a substantial portion of the floor space with the specific territorial quality of something that was very large and was in the place where it lived and was not expecting company. His tawny fur caught the thin light from the entrance. His eyes, open, amber, tracked Zephyr from the moment he came through the door.

Zephyr stopped.

Boulder did not move.

They looked at each other across the cave with the mutual assessment of two entities that were each, in their respective categories, difficult to deal with.

Then Bás Eagla came through the entrance behind Zephyr, and Boulder rose.

He rose the way large things rose: with the sound of it first, the shift of weight and the deep resonant movement of a mass that displaced air as it moved, and then the visual of it, and the visual was something the file's three-hundred-and-forty-centimetre notation had communicated accurately in units and not at all in experience. Standing on his hind legs in the cave, his head nearly touched the ceiling. His claws, when his forepaws left the ground, were exactly what the file had said they were. His roar, when it came, was a physical event, the kind of sound that was not just heard but felt, in the chest and in the back of the knees and in a very ancient part of the brain that predated all the more recent layers.

Bás Eagla, to his own acknowledgment, stepped back one step.

Zephyr stepped forward.

This was not a decision so much as a reflex, the reflex of someone whose body had long since separated the concept of threat from the concept of something that could actually harm him, and Boulder's roar had activated the first without engaging the second. He stepped forward with his hands slightly out, in the universal posture of something that was not running, and Boulder came down off his hind legs and charged.

The charge covered the distance in a time that did not leave room for deliberation, and Boulder hit Zephyr with the full mass of him, shoulder to chest, and the result was not what Boulder expected.

Zephyr moved. He moved back, one step, two steps, the momentum of three hundred and forty centimetres of bear transferred into him and distributed through his frame in the specific way of something that was impenetrable but still subject to physics, and he hit the cave wall behind him and the cave wall sustained the damage that normally would have been sustained by the thing hitting it. Boulder pulled back, and for a moment they were at the same distance as before, and Boulder shook his head, once, with the expression of something encountering new information.

Then he came again.

This time Zephyr caught him.

It was not elegant. It was the functional, committed catch of someone with both arms out and the structural integrity to make it work, hands finding purchase in the thick fur at Boulder's shoulders, and for a moment that had a distinct quality of unreality to it, they were locked together in the centre of the cave, Boulder pushing forward with the full considerable engine of his hindquarters, Zephyr pushing back with the full considerable fact of being Zephyr.

The ground between them suffered.

Bás Eagla watched this from the cave entrance with the expression of someone assessing a situation and determining that his intervention was neither required nor especially advisable. He was also, through The Mind, tracking the

large stationary presence to the west, which had, in the last thirty seconds, become a large moving presence.

"Goroth is coming," he said, to no one in particular, since the two combatants currently locked in a test of fundamental physics were not in a position to do much with the information.

Zephyr's suit cycled to a very bright sequence, which in the enclosed space of the cave was significant. Boulder flinched, not from the brightness itself, but from the sudden change, the way any animal flinched from the unexpected, and in that half-second of recalibration Zephyr used the leverage he had and turned, and Boulder went sideways rather than forward, and they separated, and both of them stood in the aftermath of the thing they had just done, regarding each other with a quality that was no longer aggression but was not yet anything else.

Boulder snorted.

Zephyr's mask displayed something that might have been the equivalent.

"Good fight," Zephyr said.

Boulder looked at him for a long moment. Then he sat down, heavily, in the manner of something that had made a decision about a situation and was comfortable with that decision.

The entrance darkened.

Goroth filled it.

He filled it the way the file had described: towering, broad, horned helm, the double-headed spear at his back and the tattoos visible on his arms in the grey light. He was six feet eight and the entrance was built for Boulder's passage rather than his, and he had to angle his shoulders and duck the helm's horns slightly to come through, and the effect of him emerging from that constraint into the main space of the cave was considerable. His amber eyes moved

across the scene: Bás Eagla at the near wall, Zephyr in the centre, Boulder seated in the middle distance looking unbothered.

He looked at the damage to the cave floor, which was specific and recent.

He looked at Zephyr.

He looked at Boulder.

Boulder looked back at him with the expression of something that was making no particular claims about what had happened.

Goroth said something in a language that was not Swedish and was not any language in the ISP's standard field agent training materials. It was a short statement, two or three syllables, directed at Boulder. Boulder's ears moved. The quality of the cave changed slightly, the way a room changed when the largest authority in it had spoken.

Then Goroth looked at Bás Eagla, because Bás Eagla was the one who was standing still and had not visibly been involved in what had happened to the floor, and that made him the one most likely to provide a coherent account.

"We are agents of the International Security Program," Bás Eagla said. "You are registered with our organisation. You have not made scheduled contact in thirteen days, which crossed the threshold for a welfare check. We came to confirm you are in good health and to understand the reason for the gap in contact." He paused. "We are not here to cause difficulty. We are aware that we entered your home without invitation, and we acknowledge that Boulder's response was appropriate given the circumstances."

Goroth looked at him for a long time.

Goroth was not a man who spoke quickly, and the ISP file had noted this, and Bás Eagla did not fill the silence.

Finally, Goroth spoke. His voice was what his size suggested it would be, low and unhurried, with the specific quality of a person who said what they meant and had no practice in saying more. His English was functional and deliberate,

with the cadence of someone who had learned it as a tool rather than a language.

"Thirteen days," he said.

"Yes."

"I do not call."

"We noticed."

A pause. Goroeth looked at Zephyr again, then at Boulder, then at the floor.

"He fought you."

"He did," Zephyr said. "He is good."

Boulder's ears moved again.

Goroeth set the butt of his spear on the cave floor and leaned on it in the manner of someone settling in for a conversation that was going to take the time it was going to take. "The calling," he said. "The device. I do not have it here."

"You have no communication equipment at the cave," Bás Eagla said.

"No."

"The nearest location with communication infrastructure is the village."

Goroeth tilted his head slightly. "You know the village."

"I know of it from the file. How far?"

"Half a day. One way." He was quiet for a moment. "Boulder does not like when I am gone that long. The forest has things in it. He does not like to be alone that long."

Bás Eagla absorbed this. Through The Mind he could feel the cave, the texture of the two presences in it, Goroeth and Boulder, and the specific quality of the connection between them, which was not the connection between a person

and an animal they owned but the connection between two things that had grown alongside each other long enough to become, in some functional sense, one system. Boulder's unease when Goroeth left was not performed. It was structural.

"So you do not go," Bás Eagla said.

"Not for that."

"And the ISP check-in is not a reason that outweighs that."

Goroeth looked at him steadily. "No."

There was not a great deal to argue with in that answer, and Bás Eagla did not try. He was quiet for a moment, considering the practical dimensions of the problem.

"If someone came to you," he said. "On a regular schedule. To the cave. Would you speak with them?"

Goroeth considered this. "If they came with respect," he said. "And did not stay long."

"I will put that in the report," Bás Eagla said. "It is possible the ISP can arrange a field contact rotation. Someone local who makes the trip on the schedule instead of requiring you to make it."

Goroeth was quiet for a moment, then nodded. One movement, definitive, the nod of a man who did not waste the gesture.

Zephyr, who had been standing through this exchange in the posture of someone who was being very patient and was doing it visibly, looked at Boulder.

Boulder looked back at him.

"Is he always like this?" Zephyr asked, addressing Goroeth but watching Boulder.

"He does not know you," Goroeth said. "He does not fight people he knows."

"Fair," Zephyr said. "Can I sit next to him?"

A pause. Goroeth looked at Boulder. Something passed between them that was not language and was not nothing.

Boulder shifted slightly to one side.

Zephyr sat.

He sat on the cave floor next to a bear that had just charged him twice with full intent, and Boulder regarded him from close range with the amber intelligence of something that was reassessing its initial conclusion, and after a moment Boulder turned his head away and looked at the cave entrance, and Zephyr's mask settled into an expression of complete satisfaction.

Bás Eagla watched this.

Goroeth watched this.

"Your companion," Goroeth said, to Bás Eagla. "He is strange."

"Yes," Bás Eagla said.

"He fought Boulder and sat next to him."

"That is consistent with his general approach to most situations."

Goroeth looked at Zephyr and Boulder for a moment longer, then at Bás Eagla, and the quality of his expression shifted in a small way that was not quite approval but was in the same neighbourhood. He moved to the fire pit and crouched beside it, pulling a piece of tinder from the stack nearby and beginning, methodically, to rebuild the fire.

"You will stay," he said. It was not precisely a question.

"Briefly," Bás Eagla said. "We have more stops on this trip."

Goroth nodded and continued building the fire. Boulder had, in the last several minutes, lowered his head to his forepaws in the manner of something that had made a comprehensive reassessment of a situation and arrived at a comfortable conclusion. Zephyr sat next to him and did not move and did not say anything, which was, for Zephyr, a significant accommodation.

Outside the cave, the Swedish forest did what it did, which was continue in all directions for a very long time.

They left an hour later, in the company of the fire and the smell of it, and Goroth stood at the cave entrance and watched them go the way he probably watched most things go: without visible feeling about it, simply watching, until they were gone.

Boulder watched too, from behind Goroth's left knee, his amber eyes tracking Zephyr specifically for the longest portion of the distance.

When the treeline closed behind them, Zephyr looked back once.

"The ISP should absolutely send someone local," he said. "He is not going to change. That is not a criticism, it is just a fact."

"I am aware," Bás Eagla said. "I noted it in the field log."

They walked in silence for a few minutes through the forest, the cold air steady around them and the ground the same complicated terrain as before, and then Zephyr said:

"Boulder is the best one we have met."

"Boulder is not an ISP contact."

"Boulder is the best one we have encountered on this trip."

"He charged you twice."

"And then he let me sit next to him. That is character development." Zephyr stepped over a root without looking at it. "Goroth is good too. Quiet. Honest. Says exactly what he means and not one word more."

"You find that admirable," Bás Eagla said.

"I find it interesting. You do that too, you know."

Bás Eagla said nothing.

"You and Goroth," Zephyr said. "Same energy. Silent. Direct. Bear next to you."

"I do not have a bear."

"Metaphorical bear." Zephyr's mask displayed something fond. "I am the metaphorical bear."

Bás Eagla walked.

"I am not going to respond to that," he said.

"You do not have to," Zephyr said, cheerfully. "I already know the answer."

Ahead of them, Astrid's vehicle was visible at the treeline, a dark shape against the pale morning. The engine was running. She had, apparently, decided that keeping the heat on was worth the fuel.

Bás Eagla picked up the next folder from the bag as they walked.

"Greece," he said.

"Read it out," Zephyr said. And then, after a pause: "Please."

Bás Eagla opened the file.

Chapter Six

THE CINDER ARTISAN

Bás Eagla read the Greece file on the flight south, and the Greece file was different from the others.

"Subject: Emberlash. Listed aliases: the Cinder Artisan, Ashwright, Father of Flame. Birthday, October thirteenth. Gender, male. Race, human, self-modified technologist." He paused at the classification. "Threat tier: high."

Zephyr, who had been looking out the window at the Mediterranean approaching below them, turned around.

"High."

"The file notes it escalates to extreme under certain operational conditions." Bás Eagla continued reading. "Background. Originally a pyrotechnics engineer of some distinction. Exiled from legitimate industry following a disputed explosion, officially logged as an accident. Retooled his skills into vigilante operations before transitioning into arson for hire and theatrical terror contracts. The ISP file categorises him as an active threat currently under conditional monitoring as part of a deferred prosecution agreement coordinated with Greek authorities."

"A deferred prosecution agreement," Zephyr said.

"Meaning the ISP vouched for him in exchange for cooperation and registration. He is not technically in custody. He is technically an asset, with conditions."

"An asset who burns things for money."

"A former asset who burned things for money, who has allegedly ceased operational activity under the terms of the agreement." Bás Eagla turned the page. "Appearance. Full-body heat-resistant combat suit, matte black with orange heat-channel seams that glow under thermal load. Insect-like

silhouette. Heat-dissipation fins along the spine. Helmet with reinforced visor. Back-mounted multi-canister flamethrower system. Red and amber micro-LEDs." He set the file down briefly. "The intake notes describe him as an eerie, flickering presence in darkness."

"How long since contact?"

"Seventeen days." Bás Eagla looked at the last page. "Personality section. Intense. Cunning. Treats fire as an artistic medium. Describes himself as a fire composer rather than a pyromaniac. A nihilist aesthete. Socially cold." He closed the file. "The file does not list any known associates. No family. No partners. No affiliates currently active."

Zephyr was quiet for a moment.

"And he is in Greece."

"His registered address is an abandoned industrial facility on the outskirts of Athens. The file calls it a warehouse laboratory." Bás Eagla put the file back in the folder. "We go there first."

"High threat tier," Zephyr said, not as a concern, simply as a note.

"We are not here to apprehend him. We are here to confirm contact."

"I know." Zephyr looked back out the window. "I am just noting it. For context."

Bás Eagla noted it too, internally, and said nothing further.

Athens from the air was white and ochre and sprawling, the kind of city that accumulated rather than planned, ancient things and modern things occupying the same geography with the pragmatism of a place that had been inhabited continuously for long enough that it had stopped trying to reconcile the two. The light was sharp and warm in the way of the Mediterranean in the late afternoon, cutting hard shadows from everything it touched.

The industrial district on the city's western edge was older and denser than the rest, warehouses and processing facilities and the remnants of infrastructure that had served functions nobody currently required. Several of the buildings were derelict. Several more were occupied in the specific way of buildings that were occupied without official acknowledgment.

The address in the file resolved, at ground level, into a large warehouse facility set back from the road behind a perimeter fence. And the perimeter fence was covered in police tape.

Not a small amount of it. The methodical, comprehensive kind of police tape that indicated not a single incident but a sustained scene, the kind that had been applied carefully and was going to stay applied until everything that needed to be documented had been documented.

Bás Eagla stood outside the fence and looked at the tape and then at the building behind it.

Through The Mind he scanned the facility. Empty. Not recently-vacated empty but thoroughly-processed empty, the specific texture of a space that had been gone through by a number of people with a specific and methodical purpose and then left. No presences inside.

"He is not here," he said.

Zephyr looked at the police tape. "The police found him before we did."

"It appears so."

"Do we know which station?"

Bás Eagla was already reaching for the field communications unit.

The police station was twenty minutes from the warehouse by car, a functional and unremarkable building that smelled the way police stations smelled everywhere: a combination of old coffee, documentation, and the particular

institutional tension of a place where people spent a lot of time waiting for things they did not want to happen.

The desk officer spoke English with the resigned fluency of someone who dealt with international contacts often enough that they had stopped finding it noteworthy, and the ISP clearance documentation that Bás Eagla produced caused the specific sequence of phone calls and supervisory consultations that always happened when institutional clearance met institutional territory. It took twelve minutes. At the end of the twelve minutes a detective appeared who had the demeanour of someone who had been expecting this visit and was not thrilled about it but had accepted its inevitability.

"Your man," the detective said, "has been here for three days. Brought in on arson charges. An old abandoned refinery on the north side, one he apparently used before and decided to revisit." He looked at the ISP documentation.

"Your agreement with him specified he ceased operational activity."

"It did," Bás Eagla said.

"He did not cease operational activity."

"That is noted."

"We have been building additional charges since he arrived. The man talks. He does not stop talking. We have had four officers rotate through the interrogation room because he exhausts them." The detective looked at Zephyr briefly, in the way everyone looked at Zephyr briefly in spaces where Zephyr did not fit the expected parameters, and returned to Bás Eagla. "You want to speak with him."

"We do."

The detective considered this with the expression of a man deciding whether the bureaucratic simplification this represented was worth whatever complications these two were going to introduce. He decided it was.

"Fifteen minutes," he said. "I will have an officer outside the door. If anything breaks, the room, the subject, or the agreement between your organization and ours, I am ending the access immediately."

"Understood," Bás Eagla said.

The interrogation room was small and lit with the flat, even light of a place that did not want shadows because shadows were where things hid. There was a table, bolted, and two chairs on one side and one on the other, and on the one chair sat Emberlash.

He was not in the suit. The suit had presumably been confiscated, which made sense, and without it he was a man of moderate height in a thin detention jumpsuit with burn scarring visible on his hands and his neck and the side of his jaw, and amber eyes that were doing the thing the file had described: a faint internal glow, the retinal heat-filter implants catching the fluorescent light and giving them a quality that was not biological in the standard sense.

He looked at Bás Eagla when they came in, and then at Zephyr, and his expression did not change in any significant way. It was the expression of a man who was very rarely surprised and had made a kind of peace with the tedium of that.

Bás Eagla sat. Zephyr stood, because the room did not have a chair adequate to the purpose.

"ISP," Emberlash said. He said it differently from all the others. Not flat, not wary, not theatrically disdainful. He said it the way he might have said the name of a moderate weather system: acknowledging and fundamentally unimpressed. "They sent a shadow creature and a neon sign."

"We are here for a welfare check," Bás Eagla said. "You missed seventeen days of scheduled contact."

"I was busy."

"Burning a refinery."

"Working." The distinction was, apparently, significant to him. "The refinery was a project. It had been in planning for some time. The agreement with your organization specified I would cease commercial operations. Artistic projects were not addressed in the language of the agreement."

"The agreement specified cessation of all operational activity," Bás Eagla said.

"Art is not an operation." He said this without heat, which was its own kind of irony. "Art is a necessity. The distinction matters."

Bás Eagla looked at him for a moment. Through The Mind he was reading Emberlash with the careful attention he gave to people who were more complicated than their surface, and Emberlash was considerably more complicated than his surface. There was the expected cold certainty, the specific flatness of a man who had built his entire self around a framework that justified everything he did within it. But underneath that, something else. Something alert and coiled and not at peace in the way the flat surface implied. Emberlash was waiting for something. He had been waiting for it since before they arrived, since possibly before he was arrested. He was waiting and he was not going to say what he was waiting for.

"The deferred prosecution agreement is now void," Bás Eagla said. "You violated its terms. The ISP will need to renegotiate with Greek authorities regarding your status, and the outcome of that renegotiation is not guaranteed to favour you. I want you to understand that clearly."

"I understand it."

"And?"

Emberlash looked at him with the amber eyes and the faint internal glow.

"And," he said, with something that was almost amusement but lived in a colder neighbourhood, "you should leave this building. Both of you. You will not survive what comes next."

Bás Eagla looked at him.

It was not a threat directed at them. The tone was wrong for a threat. It was a statement of environmental fact, the kind a person made when they knew what was coming and had made whatever peace with it they were going to make, and the thing they were warning you about was not something they controlled.

"What comes next," Bás Eagla said.

Emberlash said nothing.

Through The Mind, Bás Eagla was already reaching outward, through the walls of the station, into the street outside, reading the texture of the immediate vicinity the way he had read every environment they had entered on this trip. People on the pavement. Traffic. A delivery vehicle. A man walking a dog.

And something else. Two streets over and moving. Moving fast, and moving with a specific quality he had not encountered before, a heat signature that The Mind registered not as temperature but as a fundamental property of the thing's existence, as if the fire was not something it carried but something it was made of. It was heading directly for the station. It had been heading for it since before he started looking.

He stood.

"Zephyr," he said.

Zephyr had already turned toward the door.

She came through the front wall.

Not the door, not a window. The wall, the exterior wall of the police station on the street-facing side, which turned out to be substantially less of an obstacle than walls typically were when the thing coming through them generated plasma at twenty-five hundred degrees Celsius. The section of wall she came through folded inward rather than outward, the structural materials doing

what structural materials did when they were introduced to temperatures that exceeded every assumption baked into their engineering.

Ravi came through the gap she had made and the light she brought with her changed the room.

There was no other way to describe it. The station's fluorescent overhead lighting became irrelevant. The light she produced was the light of something that was burning from the inside, her hair in full cascade, molten and flowing and throwing orange and white across every surface in the building, the magma-veins in her skin at full brightness, her eyes the swirling gold of something that was not a temperature and was not a colour but was both at once.

She was looking for her father and she was doing it the way someone who was made of fire looked for something: by making the environment irrelevant to everything except the search.

The station erupted.

Not literally, not yet, but in the way of a space that had just had its fundamental assumptions about what was possible rearranged without notice. Officers were moving. People in the waiting area were moving. Someone was trying to reach something that might have been a fire suppression system. The detective who had granted them access appeared briefly in a doorway and looked at the hole in his wall and then at Ravi and then back at the hole in his wall and made a decision about his immediate priorities.

Bás Eagla was already moving.

He moved through the station the way he moved through environments when speed mattered more than presence, shadow-stepping between positions, not teleporting but moving through the space between spaces, and the immediate problem was not Ravi's temperature or her power but the people around her who were not capable of surviving either. The station had at minimum twenty people in it. Several of them were already too close to her volcanic aura, close enough to feel it.

"Clear the building," he said to the nearest officer, in the even tone of someone for whom this was a sentence rather than a panic. "Everyone out. Now. All exits, not this room."

The officer looked at him. Looked at Ravi. Made the right calculation.

Bás Eagla turned to Ravi.

She was scanning the station, her head moving, and the intelligence in those gold eyes was clear and present, she was not mindless, she was not feral, she was a person looking for someone and burning everything in her immediate radius that was flammable as a side effect of existing at full power in an enclosed space. The ceiling above her was beginning to discolour.

"He is in the back," Bás Eagla said.

She turned to look at him. He was aware, through The Mind, of the heat field she was projecting, the specific radius within which a human without protection would begin to experience serious harm. He was also aware that his war attire was rated for projectiles and blunt force and not for sustained proximity to a biological fire source operating at this output level.

He was aware of this and he did not move back.

"He is in the back," he said again, steadily. "Interrogation room three. He is not harmed. If you walk through this station burning it, you will harm people who have not done anything to him, and you will not get to him faster. You will get to him slower because the building will be structurally compromised before you reach that room."

Ravi looked at him. The gold eyes were not calm but they were thinking.

"Who are you," she said. Her voice had a quality to it, a resonance beneath the words, like sound produced in proximity to something very hot.

"ISP. We are here to see your father. We are not his enemies."

A pause.

"He does not have enemies," she said. "He has audiences."

It was the most Emberlash sentence she could have said, and it came out of her with the specific flatness of something learned rather than invented, a phrase she had heard enough times that it had become reflex. Bás Eagla noted this and filed it.

"Then we are an audience," he said. "Let me take you to him without burning the building down."

Something shifted in her. Not the fire, the fire did not change. Something behind it.

Then Zephyr appeared from the side corridor.

He appeared the way Zephyr appeared in situations that required his specific qualities: large, bright, moving with the specific unhurried momentum of something that was not going to stop but was also not currently trying to hurt anything. His suit had cycled to a sequence that in the context of Ravi's light output was doing something interesting, the neon colours refracting against her orange-white, producing interference patterns on the ceiling that were, objectively, quite striking.

Ravi turned to face him and her hair moved with her, the lava-cascade swinging, and she read him the way her father read a burning building: assessing fuel load, blast radius, structural integrity.

"You are not human," she said.

"Not conventionally," Zephyr agreed. "Also not flammable, which I think is relevant right now."

She looked at him with the sustained attention of someone whose power had never previously encountered something it simply could not affect and was working through the implications of that.

"We are not here to fight you," Zephyr said. "We are not here to stop you seeing your father. We are here because the ISP had a welfare check on him scheduled and he missed it. That is the entire job. A welfare check."

A pause. In the station around them, the evacuation was still in progress, the sound of it reaching them from multiple directions, and the corridor behind Ravi had several small fires going that were going to need to be addressed.

"A welfare check," Ravi said.

"Yes."

She looked at Zephyr for a long moment. Then she looked at Bás Eagla. Then she looked at the station around her with the specific expression of someone who had arrived somewhere in a particular state and was now, at some distance from the beginning of it, assessing the state of the space.

The heat field contracted.

Not fully. But perceptibly. The ceiling above her stopped discolouring. The ambient temperature of the room dropped from something survivable-but-bad to something merely very warm. Her hair dimmed from full cascade to something closer to a controlled burn.

She was not standing down. But she was not escalating.

"Take me to him," she said.

The interrogation room door opened and Ravi walked in and for a moment the room had two kinds of amber in it, her eyes and his, and whatever passed between them was not something Bás Eagla extended The Mind into, because it was not his.

Emberlash looked at her the way the file had failed to predict he would look at anyone: with something that was not the cold aesthetic detachment of a man who treated everything as material, but with the specific quality of someone who had been waiting for a thing they would not have admitted waiting for.

He said something to her in a language that was not English and was not Greek. She said something back. Brief, direct.

Then he looked at Bás Eagla and the cold was back.

"The file does not mention her," Bás Eagla said. It was not an accusation. It was a statement of what had just become a fact that needed to be addressed.

"No," Emberlash said. "It does not."

"She will need to be registered."

Ravi looked at Bás Eagla. The molten gold eyes had the same flatness her father's had, the flatness of a person who had been told what to think about authority for long enough that it had become their own position.

"She will be handled through the ISP's standard intake process," Bás Eagla continued, with the same evenness he used for everything. "Given the circumstances of today, she will also be assessed in relation to what occurred in this building. Nobody was killed. Several officers sustained heat exposure. The outcome will depend on how the assessment goes."

"And if I refuse?" Ravi said.

"Then the outcome is determined by Greek authorities rather than the ISP, and I cannot tell you what that outcome looks like." He looked at her steadily. "The ISP option is the better one. I am telling you that plainly because you deserve to have it stated plainly."

Something moved through her expression. Something that was not her father's coldness and was not her fire and was, possibly, the thing underneath both of those that was still forming.

She looked at Emberlash.

He looked back at her, and whatever he communicated in that look was sufficient.

"Fine," she said.

It took four hours to process the handover, and it was the most paperwork Bás Eagla had encountered on any stop of the trip. The Greek authorities were not simple about it and the ISP field liaison who arrived from the Athens office was not simple about it either, and Zephyr spent most of those four hours standing in the station's car park, which was the only space that could accommodate him with reasonable comfort after the events inside.

Bás Eagla came out when it was done and stood next to him in the car park, and neither of them said anything for a moment.

The Athens evening was warm and had that specific quality of Mediterranean urban evenings, the day's heat stored in the concrete and releasing slowly, the light going amber, the city noise continuing at its own pace entirely indifferent to what had just happened in this particular building.

"She is not in any file," Zephyr said.

"No."

"He made a person. A living fire person. And the ISP had no idea."

"The intake notes for Emberlash list no known associates and no family," Bás Eagla said. "She was created after he was registered. The file was never updated."

"She came through a wall."

"She did."

"She came through a wall," Zephyr said again, with the tone of a man replaying an event that was still settling into its final shape in his memory, "because she was looking for her father. That was the whole reason. He was in a police station and she came through a wall."

Bás Eagla thought about the look on Emberlash's face when she walked through the interrogation room door. He thought about what the file had said about Emberlash's motivations, the art, the philosophy, the cold aesthetic

framework around everything he did. He thought about the thing that had been underneath all of that in the interrogation room, which the file had not described because the file had not known it existed.

"He knew she was coming," Bás Eagla said. "That is what he was waiting for when we arrived. He was not afraid. He was waiting for her to find him."

Zephyr was quiet for a moment.

"He told us to leave because he did not want us in the way."

"Yes."

"Not because he was worried about us."

"No."

Another silence.

"She keeps charcoal sketches," Bás Eagla said. "The intake officer found them in her jacket pocket during processing. Landscapes. Cities, but intact. Undamaged." He paused. "I do not think she knows he keeps copies."

Zephyr looked at him.

"How do you know he keeps copies?"

"The file mentions a sealed, fireproof folio in the warehouse that was recovered by Greek authorities during the search. Contents listed as paper documents of personal significance." Bás Eagla looked at the car park entrance where the liaison's vehicle was parked. "The file was written before she existed. But somebody in the intake chain updated the evidence log from the warehouse search and did not connect the folio to the subject."

Zephyr said nothing for a moment.

"That," he said eventually, "is a very complicated man."

"Yes," Bás Eagla said.

They stood in the Athens evening, and after a moment Bás Eagla reached into the bag and removed the second to last folder.

"Tanzania," he said.

Zephyr took it from him without being asked. He opened it and read the first page in the warm amber light of the evening.

"Read it out," Bás Eagla said, which was not something he had said before.

Zephyr looked at him.

Bás Eagla looked at the city.

Zephyr began to read.

Chapter Seven

THE SCRAP TITAN

Zephyr read the Tanzania file on the flight south from Athens, and he read it with the same deliberate competence he had brought to the Sweden file, and when he finished he set it down and was quiet for longer than usual.

"Subject," he had said, shortly after Athens, "Thark. Known as the Scrap Titan. Full designation: the Pilot of the Thousand-Form Engine. Race classification, goblin artificer, born of human parents. Alignment listed as chaotic neutral. Driven by survival and the accumulation of scrap."

"A goblin," Bás Eagla had said.

"Born of human parents," Zephyr had specified. "The file notes this distinction without explaining it."

"How long since contact?"

"Eighteen days. Which, the file notes, is actually better than his usual average." Zephyr had turned the page. "He pilots a construct he calls the Bone-Gears. It appears to be a large, shifting machine built from iron, hardened oak, monster bones, and glowing green vents. He can reconfigure it into nine different combat forms instantly." He had paused. "The file lists all nine forms. Should I read them?"

"Give me the relevant ones."

"They are all potentially relevant. It is nine forms." He had looked at the page. "He can fly, shoot missiles, suction things, punch with spring-loaded fists, become a turret, deploy a rotating spiked shield, become a tank with caterpillar tracks, drive at high speed while punching, or attach a chainsaw to himself and charge."

A pause.

"Nine forms," Bás Eagla had said.

"Nine."

The rest of the file had been less informative: registered address listed as a small structure in a valley in northern Tanzania, no fixed employment, no known associates, contact history described as sporadic and somewhat adversarial in tone. The intake agent's notes included the observation that Thark had described the ISP as, quote, a fancy club for people who want to feel important about themselves, and had agreed to registration only because the alternative involved consequences he found inconvenient.

Bás Eagla had closed the folder.

"He does not like us," Zephyr had said.

"Most of the people on this list do not like us."

"He specifically does not like us."

"We will go anyway."

Zephyr had looked out the window at the darkness above the Indian Ocean and had not said anything further, and the quality of his silence had the texture of someone running through nine different configurations of a potential problem and not arriving at a number he liked.

Tanzania from the air was a different world from everything that had come before on this trip. The landscape below the jet as they descended was the kind of landscape that did not try to be anything other than what it was: the Rift Valley spreading in all directions with the specific grandeur of something that had been shaped by forces operating on a timescale that made human concerns feel provisional, the dry gold of the savanna grading into the green of the valley floors, the morning light coming in flat and enormous from the east and making everything it touched look ancient.

The local ISP contact, a compact and efficient man named Deo who had the manner of someone who had done enough field coordination to have removed all the unnecessary parts of the job from his process, met them at the airstrip

and drove them north without comment on their appearance, which Bás Eagla noted and found professionally admirable.

"The valley is forty minutes," Deo said. "The track ends two kilometres before the structure. The structure is described in the file as a hut. I have not seen it personally."

"What do you know about him?" Zephyr asked.

"I know what the file says. I know he has not caused problems in this region that have come to my attention. I know the locals in the nearest settlement call the machine 'the iron ancestor' and consider it either a good omen or a very bad one depending on which elder you ask." Deo paused. "I know I am dropping you two kilometres from the structure and waiting at the vehicle."

"That seems reasonable," Bás Eagla said.

Through The Mind, he was already reaching outward as the vehicle moved through the valley, reading the landscape ahead. Wildlife, the continuous productive hum of a healthy ecosystem, birds and small mammals and something large and patient to the west that was probably an elephant. The valley itself had the texture of a place that had been doing what it did for a very long time and was not interested in interruptions.

The structure appeared when they crested a low ridge: a small hut under an acacia tree in the valley floor, exactly as the file described, with the long shade of the acacia falling across it in the morning light. It was the most modest residence they had visited on the entire trip by a significant margin.

Of the Bone-Gears, there was no sign.

Of Thark, there was no sign.

Bás Eagla read the valley through The Mind.

Nothing in or around the hut. Nothing in the immediate treeline. Nothing to the north or south that registered as the specific quality of a goblin artificer waiting to do something.

He told himself this was fine.

He did not entirely believe it.

They walked the two kilometres in the morning heat, which was already considerable at this hour and was going to become more considerable, and the valley was quiet in the specific way of a place that knew what was in it and was not going to tell you.

Zephyr walked and scanned the ridgeline above them on both sides in the patient way of someone whose threat assessment was primarily visual and comprehensive.

Bás Eagla walked and scanned everything else.

The hut was empty. He confirmed this before they reached it, through The Mind, and confirmed it again when they arrived. The interior was small and practical and contained evidence of recent habitation: tools, scattered components, pieces of machinery in various states of assembly, a sleeping area with the particular disorder of someone who prioritised function over organisation. A workbench along one wall was covered in what appeared to be half-finished modifications to something mechanical.

No Thark.

"He is not here," Zephyr said.

"No," Bás Eagla said. "He is not."

He extended The Mind outward further, past the immediate area, out to the ridgelines, the rocky outcrops, the dried riverbed to the east, the stand of trees to the north. The valley was telling him things and some of them he did not like. There was something large and mechanical to the north-east, underground or below grade somehow, its presence registered through The Mind not as a living thing but as a constructed thing with a power source that was active and warm. And there was something on the western ridge, at

altitude, very still, with the specific quality of a person who was not moving because they were watching and waiting and had chosen not to be found.

Two things. Two positions.

He opened his mouth to say something to Zephyr.

The ground thirty metres to their north exploded upward.

The Bone-Gears came out of the earth the way something that had been burrowed in the Tread-Terror configuration and switched to the Aero-Raider as it breached came out of the earth: violently, loudly, with the sound of several tonnes of iron and oak and monster bone reassembling itself in mid-air in a process that was approximately as loud as the breach itself. The machine was enormous. The file had communicated this in measurements and had not communicated it at all in any way that mattered, because the Bone-Gears at full height in open air was something that had to be seen to understand, and understanding it changed the available responses.

Thark sat in the central pilot's seat, exposed, a small green figure in a chaos of reconfiguring metal, and he was cackling. The cackle carried across the valley with the particular quality of someone who had been waiting for this moment for at minimum eighteen days and was having the time of their life.

"ISP," Thark shouted, in a voice that was higher-pitched than his machine suggested it should be and about three times as loud as his size suggested it could be. "You finally came! Do you know how long I have been waiting in that hole? Do you have any idea?"

"Eighteen days," Bás Eagla said.

"Eighteen days," Thark confirmed. "Eighteen days in a hole. Because I knew you were coming and I wanted it to be dramatic. Was it dramatic?"

The Bone-Gears deployed its exhaust pipes. The seeking missiles loaded.

"Run," Thark said, with enormous satisfaction, and fired.

Zephyr moved first.

He moved the way he moved when things were incoming: directly toward them, which was counterintuitive and also correct, because the seeking missiles tracked heat and motion and Zephyr's suit ran so hot thermally that the missiles' tracking systems had a fundamental disagreement about where he was relative to where the sensors said he was, and two of the three veered off course and the third hit him in the chest and the result for the missile was conclusive and the result for Zephyr was that he took one step back.

He looked down at his chest.

"Good," he said. "Let us do this."

He moved toward the Bone-Gears at the speed Zephyr moved when he had decided to move, which was the speed of something that was not trying to be subtle about it, and the Bone-Gears reconfigured.

It was fast. Faster than anything that size had a right to be. The exhaust pipes retracted and the legs changed and the arms extended and the spring-loaded gauntlets locked into place and the Piston-Pummel configuration was standing where the Aero-Raider had been in the time it took Zephyr to cover half the distance between them.

The haymaker came.

The arm extended ten feet and the punch hit Zephyr with the full kinetic commitment of a spring-loaded system designed to produce maximum knockback, and Zephyr went backward six metres and hit the ground with both feet and one hand and came back up already running.

"That," he said, "was better."

Thark cackled.

That was when Bás Eagla felt the western ridge.

He felt it because something on the western ridge had just made a decision. The still, waiting presence up there had moved from the category of watching

to the category of acting, and the action it was taking was the very specific action of a person acquiring a target through a scope, and the target they were acquiring was Zephyr.

He had perhaps two seconds.

He did not shout. He shadow-stepped, sinking into the ground and emerging ten metres to Zephyr's left, and he said one word:

"Down."

Zephyr, whose trust in Bás Eagla's assessments was absolute and instantaneous, dropped.

The shot crossed the valley a quarter of a second later. It was a long-range shot, precisely placed, with the specific confidence of someone who did not miss at this distance. It would have been a headshot. It connected instead with the side of Zephyr's mask, and the mask, being what the mask was, absorbed it completely and sent it back, and the return velocity of the projectile was enough to cause a small impact crater in the rock face behind Zephyr's previous position.

There was a pause from the western ridge. The quality of it was the quality of a person recalibrating very quickly.

Bás Eagla was already moving.

He found the sniper by following the line of the shot backward through the landscape, confirming the position through The Mind, and reaching the base of the western ridge in the time it took Thark to switch the Bone-Gears into the Piston configuration again and Zephyr to survive the resulting exchange.

Behind him, the valley had become loud. He filtered it.

The ridge was steep and rocky and would have been difficult terrain for most people. Bás Eagla went up it as shadow when the shadow was available and as himself when it was not, moving in the pattern his grandfather had taught

him, efficient and continuous and giving nothing away about where he was going to be next.

The sniper was repositioning. Bás Eagla felt them moving, shifting position to get a new angle, the deliberate unhurried movement of someone who was very good at this and was not panicking about having missed.

He emerged from the shadow behind them.

The sniper was large, armored in weathered grey-brown plates that blended into the rock face with evident intent, a hood casting the helmet in shadow, a long-range rifle currently being swung to a new position. The right arm had the dull gleam of something cybernetic.

The sniper turned the moment Bás Eagla emerged. The reaction time was exceptional. The rifle came around and the visor lit with the blue of active targeting systems and the cybernetic arm moved to lock the weapon in place, all of it happening in under a second.

Bás Eagla was not there when the barrel arrived. He was two metres to the left, already inside the weapon's useful range.

"You are not in the file," Bás Eagla said.

The sniper did not respond. He dropped the rifle to his back in a motion that suggested this was not the first time the engagement distance had collapsed on him, and the cybernetic arm shifted configuration and the grappling mechanism deployed, a cable and hook that crossed the gap between them in a fraction of a second.

Bás Eagla let it pass through him.

Intangibility had a specific effect on people who had launched something physical at you: it created a pause, involuntary, the half-second of the brain registering that the expected impact had not occurred and recalculating. Bás Eagla used the pause.

He did not use it violently. He used it to close distance, and when he was close enough he applied the Comhrac principle he had been using since the first fight of his life: not force against force, but pressure against the points where force became fragile. The sniper's right arm was cybernetic and therefore different, but the left shoulder was not, and the knee was not, and the neck was not, and the specific combination of pressure applied to two of those three in the right sequence produced a controlled descent to the ground that was not harmful and was also not reversible without cooperation.

The sniper was on one knee, left arm pinned, Bás Eagla's grip on the pressure point at his shoulder maintaining the position.

"You are not in the file," Bás Eagla said again. "You were not expected. Who hired you?"

A pause.

"The goblin," the sniper said. His voice was even and unhurried, the voice of someone who had been in worse positions than this and was doing the calculation about which response produced the best outcome.

"Thark hired an independent contractor to ambush an ISP welfare check."

"He said it was a test run." The sniper's visor was still active, the blue glow of the targeting systems running even in close quarters. "He said the ISP would send people and he wanted to see if they were worth fighting. He offered scrap. I needed scrap."

Bás Eagla looked at him for a moment.

"You needed scrap," he said.

"The armor required components. He had components. It was an exchange."

Below them in the valley, there was a sound like a large amount of iron switching from one configuration to another accompanied by Thark shouting something that might have been a taunt or might have been a technical observation about the reconfiguration, it was difficult to tell.

"What is your name?" Bás Eagla asked.

A pause.

"Shade," the sniper said.

"That is a designation. What is your name?"

The pause was longer this time.

"Kael," he said.

Bás Eagla released the pressure point. He did not step back very far, because stepping back very far from someone with a cybernetic arm and a rifle on their back would have been imprecise, but he gave enough space to communicate that the hold was over.

"I am going to tell you what I told the person we spoke to in Athens," he said.

"The ISP option is better than the alternative. The alternative, in this case, is Greek authorities. In this case it is Tanzanian authorities." He paused. "Stay on this ridge. Do not fire again. When we are done in the valley, I will want to speak with you further."

Kael looked at him through the visor.

"You are not arresting me," he said.

"Not at this moment, no. I am managing a sequence of priorities." Below them, something very large had just made a sound like a tank shifting into high gear. "My partner is currently dealing with a nine-form combat machine and I would like to return to that situation."

Something in Kael's posture shifted, fractionally. It was not quite amusement and it was not quite respect and it was somewhere in between those things.

"The goblin has been planning this for weeks," he said.

"I am beginning to understand that," Bás Eagla said, and dropped off the ridge.

He emerged from the shadow at the valley floor in time to find the Bone-Gears in the Vacuum-Vortex configuration, which the file had described as top-heavy with arms fusing into a massive wooden intake valve, and which in practice looked like someone had attached a building-sized maw to a machine and asked it to express an opinion about everything in its immediate vicinity.

The Great Inhale was, if nothing else, an accurate name.

The suction it generated pulled the loose material of the valley floor, dried grass and dust and small rocks, into a cone that was impressive in its radius and was currently pointed at Zephyr, who was leaning into it the way you leaned into a strong wind, which was to say he was not going anywhere but was also not finding this entirely comfortable.

"There is a sniper on the western ridge," Bás Eagla said, arriving at Zephyr's side.

"I noticed a headshot that did not work," Zephyr said, still leaning into the suction.

"He is not in our file. He was hired by Thark. I have spoken with him. He is staying on the ridge."

Zephyr turned to look at him, which required some effort against the suction. "You had a conversation with a sniper while I was fighting a nine-form machine."

"It was brief."

"Brief," Zephyr said.

The Bone-Gears switched forms. The Great Inhale reversed.

The Trash Belch hit them both with the collected debris of the previous several seconds of suction, compressed and high-pressure, and Zephyr took it across the chest and Bás Eagla became intangible half a second before it reached him, which meant the debris passed through him without effect, and then he

was solid again and Thark was already mid-configuration, the machine grinding and reshaping itself, gears locking and plates swinging, and the Phalanx-Ram configuration assembled itself in the time it took to register the change was happening.

The rotating spiked shield was exactly what the file said it was. It was a wall of metal and bone that moved like a buzzsaw, and Thark was behind it and coming forward, and the configuration was immune to frontal attack and was not, therefore, Zephyr's problem to solve from the front.

Zephyr went around it.

He went around it the way Zephyr went around things, which was at the speed of the Freight Train and in a arc that was wider than Thark anticipated and tighter than physics normally allowed for someone of his dimensions, and the Bone-Gears turned to track him and the file had been accurate about one thing: it turned very slowly in this configuration.

Zephyr hit it from the side, both hands, and the configuration held but the machine moved sideways with it, Thark compensating violently with the levers, and in the moment of instability Bás Eagla put Shadow Puppetry to use, drawing solid constructs from the ground beneath the Bone-Gears' tracks, not to stop it, stopping it was not a realistic objective, but to redirect it, to introduce friction and angle into its movement and cause Thark to spend his attention on not going over rather than on whatever he was planning to do next.

"You are good," Thark shouted, from inside the configuration, with the enthusiasm of someone genuinely enjoying themselves. "You are actually good! Both of you! I did not expect this!"

"You ambushed a welfare check," Zephyr said, from the machine's left flank, looking for the next opening.

"I ambushed what I assumed would be two mid-level bureaucrats with access to resources," Thark called back. "That is what the ISP usually sends.

Administrative capacity! Not whatever you two are!" The configuration switched again. "This is the best test I have had in months!"

The Smog-Belcher assembled around him, and the valley went dark.

The choking haze was not instantaneous. It was deliberate, the machine venting thick black smoke from every available port, spreading across the valley floor in a radius that expanded fast and continuously, and within thirty seconds the immediate area was the inside of something that had no inside, no visible edge, no reference point for direction, just black greasy smoke that carried a poison component and the sound of gears reconfiguring from somewhere within it.

Bás Eagla breathed through his mask's filtration and stood still.

He did not need to see. He did not need to hear. The Mind read the smoke as easily as it read open air, and the Bone-Gears was a constructed object with a power source and therefore registered with perfect clarity regardless of what surrounded it. Thark was switching forms in the smoke, using the cover exactly as the file said he used it, and the form he was switching to had the weight distribution of the Shrapnel-Turret, the legs retracting, the chest cavity opening.

"Zephyr," Bás Eagla said, into the smoke. "Eleven metres north-north-east of your current position. Stationary. He is becoming a turret."

"Understood," Zephyr said, from somewhere in the smoke. His suit was cycling through colours that the smoke diffused into strange ambient blooms, orange and blue spreading and dispersing.

The Molten Scrap Barrage opened up.

It was a high rate of fire and the scrap was superheated and it came in a spreading pattern from the chest cannon, and in the smoke it was the most visible thing in the environment, a continuous stream of burning metal that could be tracked by the light it produced. Zephyr moved through it in the way of something that was not going to take damage but was also not going to

stand still for it, and Bás Eagla moved parallel to it through the smoke, reading Thark's position continuously, waiting.

The Overheat came next. The file said it was the turret configuration's ultimate, and the file was right: the fire nova expanded outward from the Bone-Gears' position like a breath, a ring of heat and burning pressure, and it cleared the smoke in a radius around it as a side effect, and what it revealed in that cleared radius was Zephyr, very close, having used the smoke to cover the distance.

Zephyr hit the chest cannon with both hands and the barrel bent.

The configuration was not designed to absorb force from inside its own chest cavity, and what happened next was the specific cascade of a machine that had been built for adaptability encountering a problem that adaptability could not immediately solve: the bent barrel caused a backpressure event in the firing system, and the firing system's response was to vent, and the venting hit the transition mechanism for the next form change, and for approximately four seconds the Bone-Gears was neither the Shrapnel-Turret nor anything else, just a large and very loud machine in the middle of an uncontrolled reconfiguration.

Bás Eagla walked through the dissipating smoke and put both hands on the pilot console housing, the outer casing of the structure that housed Thark's controls.

He did not use force. He used Nightmares.

It was a minimal application, precisely targeted: not the full weight of it, just enough to introduce into Thark's sensory processing the very specific experience of the Bone-Gears not responding. Every lever, every pedal, every control returning nothing. The machine going silent around him. Not real, not permanent, but immediate and absolute and for the three seconds it lasted, total.

Three seconds was enough.

When it released, the Bone-Gears was standing still with Zephyr's hands resting on the frame, which was not a threatening posture but was a very present one, and Bás Eagla was standing at the console housing, and Thark was looking out from the pilot seat with the expression of a person who had just experienced something that did not fit any category in their threat assessment library.

"What was that," Thark said.

"A targeted neurological effect," Bás Eagla said. "It is not permanent. Your machine is intact."

Thark looked at him. He looked at Zephyr. He looked at the valley around them, the dissipating smoke, the gouged earth, the shadow constructs dissolving back into the ground.

"You broke my barrel," he said to Zephyr.

"You hired someone to shoot me in the head," Zephyr said.

"I wanted to test whether you were interesting," Thark said, with the defensiveness of someone who found this a completely reasonable explanation. "You passed! Both of you! Especially the shadow one, whatever he did to my controls was genuinely upsetting and I respect it."

Bás Eagla looked at him.

"We are here," he said, "for a welfare check. You have been uncontactable for eighteen days. The purpose of this visit is to confirm you are in good health."

Thark stared at him.

"I set up an eighteen-day ambush," he said.

"You are clearly in good health," Bás Eagla said. "I will note that in the report."

Thark stared at him for another moment. Then he laughed, and the laugh was exactly what the file suggested his general character would produce: enormous, genuine, completely unconcerned with whether it was appropriate.

"I like you," he said. "I did not expect to like you. Both of you. Especially you," he said, pointing at Zephyr. "You hit the barrel. That was beautiful. Nobody has ever hit the barrel before."

"It seemed like the right place to hit," Zephyr said.

The smoke had cleared fully by the time Bás Eagla climbed the western ridge again, and Kael was where he had said he would be, seated on a flat rock at the position he had used for the shot, the rifle across his knees, his visor dark.

Below them, Thark was showing Zephyr the Bone-Gears' reconfiguration mechanism with the enthusiasm of an engineer showing a peer something they were proud of, and Zephyr was listening with what appeared to be genuine interest, which it probably was.

Bás Eagla sat on the rock opposite Kael.

"You are registered with the ISP," he said. It was a guess that had become a near-certainty during the fight: the shot had been too precise, the threat assessment too accurate, the reaction time too calibrated for someone who had not been through an intake process that screened for exactly those things.

Kael looked at him.

"Possibly," he said.

"I do not have your file with me. I did not know you were going to be here. But when I return to base, I am going to look, and I am either going to find you or I am not, and if I do not find you I will begin the process of adding you." He paused. "Either way, what happened today is going into a report."

"I did not harm anyone," Kael said.

"You fired on an ISP agent."

"I fired on a very large neon figure in a valley in Tanzania who absorbed the shot without apparent consequence." He looked down the ridge at where

Zephyr was currently watching one of the Bone-Gears' configurations unfold.
"I would argue the harm threshold was not met."

Bás Eagla looked at him.

There was something in Kael's stillness that was not Gorothe's stillness and was not Bás Eagla's own stillness. It was the stillness of someone who had learned it as a survival mechanism rather than as a natural state, the specific quality of a person who had trained themselves to take up as little of the world as possible and had done it for long enough that it had become who they were.

Through The Mind, Bás Eagla read the texture of it and said nothing about what he found there.

"Check in with the ISP," he said. "On schedule. Do not take contracts that put you in opposition to ISP operations."

"The goblin did not tell me it was an ISP operation."

"I know. That is why today's outcome is what it is rather than something more complicated." He stood. "Get your armor components from Thark. Go do whatever it is you do. Check in with the ISP."

Kael watched him.

"That is all?" he said.

"That is all," Bás Eagla said.

He went back down the ridge.

Deo drove them back to the airstrip in the same professional silence as the outward journey, which Bás Eagla appreciated. The vehicle had a crack in the windshield from a piece of debris that had reached the track during the Smog-Belcher phase, and Deo had looked at it once and then not looked at it again.

"Thark is in good health," Bás Eagla said.

"Good," Deo said.

"He has agreed to check in monthly through a field contact relay rather than directly. I will arrange this through the ISP office."

"I will note it," Deo said.

From the back seat, Zephyr said: "He showed me how the reconfiguration works. The control console is entirely analogue. No electronics. He built it so it cannot be jammed or hacked or remotely interfered with." He paused. "He built the Nightmare vulnerability in himself. The controls only respond to his nervous system directly. Which is what made what you did work."

"I know," Bás Eagla said.

"He did not know that was a vulnerability until today."

"Also true."

Zephyr was quiet for a moment.

"He is going to spend the next several months figuring out how to make the console Nightmare-resistant," he said.

"Probably."

"He told me. He said, and I am quoting, 'this is the best feedback I have received in years, I am going to fix it and then I am going to invite you back so you can try again.'"

"I noted that he seemed to regard the entire engagement as a product review," Bás Eagla said.

Zephyr's mask settled into something that was the mask equivalent of a reluctant smile.

"He is also going to fix the barrel," he said. "He was actually quite pleased that I bent it. He said something about stress-testing the weak point and upgrading the housing."

"He described us as excellent test subjects," Bás Eagla said. "I read this in the intake notes before we arrived. I should have taken it as a more specific warning."

Deo said nothing, which was the appropriate response.

Bás Eagla reached into the bag and removed the last folder.

It was thinner than the others. The Japan contact had the shortest file of anyone on the list, which was either reassuring or the opposite.

He opened it.

Chapter Eight

THE WRAITH HUNTER

Bás Eagla read the Japan file on the long flight north-east from Tanzania, and he read it twice, and the second time he set it down and looked out the window at the Indian Ocean below them turning slowly from night-black to the dark blue of early morning, and he did not read it a third time.

Zephyr, who was reading nothing because he had finished the file during the first hour and had since been watching the sky change colours through his window with the unhurried attention of someone who had seen a lot of sky and still found it worth looking at, turned his head.

"Short file," he said.

"Yes."

"Shorter than all the others."

"Yes."

"It says his registered address is listed as urban cityscape, location unspecified. His birthday is unknown. His background before the Wraith encounters is orphanage, city, streets. No other contacts. No family." Zephyr looked at the file on his own knee, which he had not opened again. "The ISP did not find him. He found them."

"He walked into the ISP intake office in Tokyo unannounced," Bás Eagla said. "Fourteen months ago. He told them what he could do. He told them what he had been doing. He agreed to register because he said, and I am quoting the intake note here, he said someone should know he exists in case something goes wrong." He paused. "He has not made contact in nineteen days."

"Something may have gone wrong."

"That is a possibility."

They sat with that for a moment. Outside, the sky was getting lighter in the east, which was the direction they were flying.

"Japan," Zephyr said, after a while.

"Yes."

A pause of a different quality.

"We have been to Japan before," Zephyr said.

"We have."

Bás Eagla looked at the window. The light on it was doing something particular, the way dawn light over open water always did something particular, turning the glass into a surface that was neither reflective nor transparent but somewhere between the two.

"The shrine," Zephyr said. Not a question.

"I was not thinking about the shrine specifically," Bás Eagla said, which was not entirely true, and which Zephyr almost certainly knew was not entirely true, and neither of them pursued it further.

What he had been thinking about was the file spread across the altar of an abandoned shrine in a Japanese forest. His own history in neat handwriting, laid flat on old wood among other people's histories, waiting to be read by anyone who came looking. He had not picked it up. He had left it there, and the shrine had burned later in the fight, and he had told himself that was fine because it had only been paper.

He had thought about it considerably more than he had told anyone.

"The Wraiths in his file," Zephyr said, moving with the specific tact of changing a subject while staying in the same general area. "He can see them when others cannot. He can interact with them. The intake notes say the ISP tried to assess whether the Wraiths were genuinely supernatural entities or manifestations of his own psychology and concluded they were genuinely supernatural entities."

"The assessment team's report uses the phrase 'definitively confirmed' three times," Bás Eagla said. "Which suggests the process of confirmation was not straightforward."

"His Wraith Sense," Zephyr said. "Can you feel them? Through The Mind?"

Bás Eagla considered this. "I do not know. I have not been in proximity to a confirmed Wraith. The Mind reads living things and constructed things and, as we established in Scotland, certain classes of spiritual entities." He looked at the window. "It is possible. I would not want to make assumptions."

"So we might arrive and find a Wraith situation," Zephyr said.

"We might arrive and find any number of things. The file is thin because the ISP does not know much. He did not tell them much. He told them he existed and what he could do and that was the extent of his disclosure."

"Because he is fiercely independent and distrustful of authority," Zephyr said, reading from memory.

"That is the intake assessment, yes."

"So he is going to be very happy to see two ISP agents."

"Probably not initially, no."

Zephyr looked back out the window. The light was proper morning now, and the ocean below them was catching it.

"We will find him," he said. The simplicity of it was not casualness. It was the specific certainty of someone who had been doing this long enough to know that the job always eventually resolved, one way or another.

Bás Eagla looked at the file one more time, at the photograph of a young man in a hooded jacket on a rooftop with a Wraith behind him the size of a building, and closed the folder.

"We will find him," he agreed.

Tokyo arrived below them looking exactly like itself, which was to say it arrived looking like a city that had decided size was not a limitation but a medium and had proceeded accordingly. From altitude it was a continuous grid interrupted by water and green space, the logic of it visible from above and completely illegible from the ground, which was where they were going.

The local ISP contact was a woman named Fujimoto who worked out of the Tokyo field office and had the manner of someone who was extremely competent and was choosing, for reasons she had decided not to share, to be pleasant about it. She met them at a private terminal and drove them into the city in a vehicle that she navigated through the traffic with the same competence.

"His last confirmed sighting was in Shinjuku," she said, in precise English. "Nineteen days ago. A security camera at a convenience store. He bought water and bandages. The camera caught his face for approximately two seconds before he moved out of frame." She glanced at them in the rearview mirror. "He appears to know where cameras are."

"He grew up on the streets," Bás Eagla said. "He would know."

"We have done some canvassing. The Shinjuku area, some of the surrounding wards. People who sleep rough or spend significant time in the urban spaces, the parks, the underpasses, the network of covered alleys in certain districts. Several people recognized his description." She paused. "No one would tell us where he was."

"They would not tell the ISP," Bás Eagla said.

"No."

"They might tell us differently."

Fujimoto looked at him in the mirror with the expression of someone who was not entirely sure what this meant but was professionally prepared to find out.

Zephyr's suit had cycled, in the enclosed space of the vehicle, through several sequences that had not gone unnoticed by passing pedestrians at the lights.

"I will drop you in Shinjuku," she said. "I will remain available by contact device. I suggest you do not lose the contact device."

"We will not," Zephyr said.

She looked at him.

"We generally do not," Bás Eagla said.

Shinjuku at mid-morning was the kind of urban environment that operated at full capacity all the time and had no quieter setting available. The streets were wide and the buildings were tall and the density of information in the visual field, the signs and the screens and the movement, was something that required active management rather than passive reception. Bás Eagla managed it the way he managed all environments: by filtering to what was relevant and letting the rest exist without engaging with it.

What was relevant was where Ethan Blackwood was.

He extended The Mind outward and found what he always found in cities: people, thousands of them, each one a thread of presence that The Mind registered and filed and, unless there was something distinctive about them, set aside. He was looking for something distinctive. Not the Wraiths, not yet, but the quality of a person who lived in a city the way a shadow lived in a room: present everywhere and nowhere specific, moving along routes that the rest of the population did not use.

"He will be elevated," Bás Eagla said. "He operates from rooftops and alleys. The file says he takes refuge in abandoned buildings. In a district like this the abandoned space is vertical, not horizontal. He will be above us."

Zephyr tilted his head back and looked up. The buildings ran up on all sides, glass and concrete, with the narrow bands of sky between them that cities produced when they got dense enough.

"He could be anywhere," Zephyr said.

"He could. But the people who sleep rough and know this area will know the patterns. Where the patrols are, where the building access is loose, where you can be without being moved on." Bás Eagla looked along the street. "We ask."

Zephyr looked at him. "We ask."

"There is a network. It has its own geography. People who live inside it know each other, or know of each other. If Ethan Blackwood has been in this district for any length of time, someone in that network has seen him."

"And they will talk to us."

"Some of them will talk to you," Bás Eagla said. "You are very good at talking to people."

Zephyr considered this. "That is accurate," he said, and started walking.

The first two conversations produced nothing, or nothing direct: a woman who sold food from a small cart near a covered walkway who had seen someone matching the description weeks ago near a specific underpass and had not seen him since; a man sleeping in a recessed doorway who said nothing at all but looked, when Zephyr described the hooded jacket, in a direction that was more specific than a look at nothing.

The direction was north-east, into a denser and older part of the district, the kind of streets that the redevelopment had not yet reached and that therefore still had the particular texture of a city layer that had been superseded but not removed.

They found a covered alley market, the kind that existed in the gaps between streets, vendor stalls under corrugated roofing with the smell of food and the sound of small commerce and the particular quality of an enclosed space that people used because it was theirs rather than because anyone had assigned it. Zephyr ducked the roofing with the ease of practice and found a stall selling grilled things on sticks and bought several and began a conversation with the

person running it that was, within approximately ninety seconds, producing results.

Bás Eagla stood at the alley entrance and watched the street and extended The Mind and waited.

He felt something on the roof above the market.

It was there and then it was not, and the speed of the transition was the speed of someone who moved very quickly and who did not want to be found and who had, in the last several seconds, understood that someone below them was looking.

"He knows we are here," Bás Eagla said.

Zephyr turned from the stall. He read Bás Eagla's face and turned back, thanked the vendor with the sincerity of someone who meant it, and stepped out of the market.

"Which way?" he said.

"He is moving. He is fast." Bás Eagla tracked the presence through The Mind, a moving point in the space above the street, crossing a rooftop and dropping to a fire escape and up again, the movement of someone who knew this urban terrain the way Gorothe knew his forest, not just the routes but the texture of them. "He is heading north. He is not panicking. He is just not going to let us catch up."

"Can you stop him?" Zephyr asked.

"Not without a confrontation I would prefer to avoid." Bás Eagla watched the presence move. "He knows we are here. He is not running from us specifically, he is running from ISP specifically. He made the same calculation Jesús made."

"So we let him run and try again."

"So we let him run and try again," Bás Eagla agreed. "Differently."

They tried differently four more times over the course of the afternoon.

The second attempt was a rooftop approach, Bás taking the shadow route up the side of a building to the level where The Mind indicated Ethan was resting, and making it to within forty metres before the presence shifted and moved and did not stop moving for eleven minutes. The speed of the response told him something: Ethan's Wraith Sense, or something adjacent to it, was operating in a way that was hard to approach without triggering. He had lived alone with supernatural awareness for years. The threshold for detecting something anomalous in his environment was calibrated differently from a standard person's.

The third attempt was Zephyr's idea: he went to an intersection that the movement patterns suggested Ethan crossed regularly, on a route between two points he had been using, and stood there visibly and obviously and simply waited, which was a significant exercise in patience for Zephyr but which he performed with the focused equanimity of someone who understood the assignment. Ethan crossed the intersection at street level, twenty metres away, and spotted Zephyr at approximately the same moment Bás Eagla spotted him through The Mind, and the speed at which he was gone was impressive even by the standards of this trip.

"He is very fast," Zephyr said, after.

"He has spent years evading things that can kill him," Bás Eagla said. "His speed is not athletic. It is architectural. He does not run faster than the environment. He knows the environment better."

The fourth attempt was Bás Eagla waiting in a shadow in an alley that he had identified as a thoroughfare for Ethan's movement, intangible, letting the presence pass within two metres of him. Ethan stopped. For seven seconds he stood completely still in the alley, which was the response of someone whose awareness had detected something without being able to identify it. He looked directly at the wall where Bás Eagla was standing. Then he looked away and walked on, quickly.

He did not run. He walked on quickly, and there was a quality to the walk that Bás Eagla, standing in the shadow and watching him go, recognised as the quality of someone who was tired in a way that sleep did not fix.

The fifth attempt was not an attempt at approach. It was a conversation with a woman who ran a small hardware shop in the area, who had known Ethan by sight for over a year, who had not told the ISP field team anything and who told Bás Eagla something, not everything, but something, in the specific way of a person deciding that whoever was in front of them was different enough from the last set of official-looking visitors to warrant a different response.

"He comes in sometimes," she said, in careful English. "For tape. For rope. For things you use when you are fixing something that keeps breaking." She looked at Bás Eagla's mask and did not comment on it. "He does not talk much. He pays. He goes." She paused. "He looked very tired the last time. Three weeks ago, maybe."

"Did he say anything?"

"He said the usual thing." She folded her hands on the counter. "He said the usual thing he says when he comes in. He says: are you all right. Not hello. Not I need tape. Are you all right." She looked at the counter for a moment. "I do not think many people have asked him that."

Bás Eagla stood with this.

"Thank you," he said.

They found him at dusk.

Not by speed or approach or strategy, but by stopping. Bás Eagla stood on a pedestrian bridge over one of the district's smaller canals and extended The Mind and stopped tracking and simply waited, the way The Mind worked best, passively, letting the city come to him rather than reaching for it.

The canal below was dark and caught the last of the light in the way water in cities did, in fragments, between the reflections of the buildings. Around him,

people crossed the bridge in both directions, going where they were going, and he stood among them like something that had decided to be still while the current moved.

Zephyr stood beside him. He had been standing beside him for twenty minutes without saying anything, which was, for Zephyr, a significant accommodation.

The presence resolved itself on a rooftop two buildings south, low to the parapet, watching them.

He had been there for several minutes. He had followed them here, which meant he had made a decision, or was making one.

Bás Eagla did not move.

"He is behind us," he said quietly. "Two buildings south, at the parapet. He has been there for a while."

"He followed us," Zephyr said.

"Yes."

"What do we do?"

"We wait," Bás Eagla said. "We let him decide."

They waited. The city moved around them. The light finished its change from amber to the dark blue of early evening, and the building lights came on in the irregular way of a city district waking up to its night self, and the canal below caught the new colours and arranged them differently.

After eleven minutes, Bás Eagla felt the presence leave the rooftop.

It came down, not to the street but to the pedestrian level of the bridge's south approach, and it moved along the bridge slowly, the way a person moved when they had decided to do something and were not rushing the doing of it.

Ethan Blackwood came to the middle of the bridge and stopped beside them.

He was exactly the file and also not the file, in the way every person they had found on this trip had been. The hooded jacket was dark and worn and the hood was down in the cooling evening air. His dark hair fell over his eyes in the way the file had described, and his eyes, when he looked at Bás Eagla, were the dark brown the file specified and also the specific kind of tired the hardware shop owner had meant.

He looked at Zephyr briefly, in the way everyone looked at Zephyr briefly, and then back at Bás Eagla.

"You have been looking for me all day," he said. His English was fluent and slightly flat, the flatness of someone who had learned to keep affect out of statements that could be used against them.

"Yes," Bás Eagla said.

"You are ISP."

"Yes."

"Welfare check," Ethan said. Not a question. He had clearly spent some of the afternoon working through the available explanations for two people who looked like them looking for him with the specific persistence they had used, and had arrived at the correct one.

"Nineteen days without contact," Bás Eagla said. "You crossed the threshold."

Ethan looked at the canal. He stood with his forearms on the bridge railing in the posture of someone who had stood on a lot of bridges and was comfortable with what bridges did, which was hold you above something you might otherwise fall into.

"I was dealing with something," he said.

"The Wraiths."

A pause. He looked at Bás Eagla with the specific attention of someone recalibrating what kind of conversation this was going to be. "You read the file."

"We read the file. It is not very long. You did not tell them much."

"I told them enough."

"You told them you existed and what you could do," Bás Eagla said. "You told them almost nothing about the Wraiths specifically. The intake notes say the assessment team spent two weeks trying to establish the nature of the entities and concluded they were definitively supernatural, which I believe was difficult for them to write."

Something moved through Ethan's expression, brief, and might have been the shadow of a laugh.

"They sent three people who could not see them and asked them to evaluate something invisible," he said. "They were very professional about it. I felt bad for them."

"What happened nineteen days ago?" Bás Eagla asked.

Ethan was quiet for a moment. Below them the canal moved.

"There was a cluster," he said. "Larger than usual. Something drew them, I do not know what, something in the district was producing what they feed on and there were more of them than I had seen in one place before." He paused. "I handled it. But it took time. And I was not in a position to make contact during that time, and then I was too tired, and then it seemed pointless."

"Pointless," Bás Eagla said.

"I registered with the ISP because I thought someone should know I exist. Not because I expected anything from the arrangement." He looked at the canal.

"Two agents flying to Japan to ask if I am all right is more than I expected from the arrangement."

"It is the arrangement," Bás Eagla said. "You are in the file. The file triggered the check. We came."

"That is very efficient."

"Are you all right?" Bás Eagla said.

Ethan turned to look at him. The question had the specific quality of the hardware shop owner's observation: it was not the usual question and he recognised it as such. He looked at Bás Eagla's skull mask and his dark robe and his pitch-black hands on the bridge railing, and he looked at Zephyr, whose suit had settled into a slow and quiet cycling of deep blues in the evening light, and he looked back at the canal.

"I am tired," he said. "But that is the usual condition."

"I understand that," Bás Eagla said.

Ethan looked at him.

"The Wraiths," Bás Eagla said. "They feed on despair and fear. You have been fighting them alone in this city for years. That is not sustainable indefinitely."

"I have been sustaining it."

"You have. That is notable." Bás Eagla looked at the canal. "It is not the same as it being fine."

A silence of some duration.

Zephyr, who had been standing on Ethan's other side with the patient presence of someone who understood when to be present and when to be quiet and was currently deploying the second of those, said: "You asked her if she was all right. The hardware shop woman."

Ethan turned to look at him.

"She mentioned it," Zephyr said simply. "She said you always ask that. Are you all right. She said she does not think many people have asked you the same."

The quality of Ethan's stillness changed. Not much. But it changed.

"I grew up in places where nobody asked," he said. "It seemed like something that should happen more."

"Yes," Zephyr said. "It should."

They stood on the bridge in the Tokyo evening, and the city around them continued with itself, and the canal below moved in its own direction, and none of the three people on the bridge said anything for a while, which was the kind of silence that was not empty.

"The check-in protocol," Ethan said finally. "Monthly."

"Monthly," Bás Eagla confirmed.

"I can do monthly." He said it with the specific quality of a commitment from someone who did not make commitments lightly, who understood that the weight of a commitment was the same whether you kept it or not and who therefore only made ones he intended to keep. "If something comes up, the way things come up, I will send a message. I did not know that was an option."

"It is an option," Bás Eagla said. "You can initiate contact. It does not have to be the scheduled prompt."

Ethan nodded. One movement.

"The Wraiths," Bás Eagla said. "You have your Wraith Sense. I have something that may or may not register them. I do not know. I have not been in confirmed proximity to one before." He paused. "If you ever need a second pair of eyes that might actually be useful, the contact option exists for that too."

Ethan looked at him for a long moment.

"You are not what I expected the ISP to send," he said.

"We are generally not," Zephyr said.

Something shifted at the edge of Ethan's expression, not quite a smile but related to one, and then it was gone and he was looking at the canal again.

"All right," he said. "Monthly. I will send a message if something comes up." He pushed off the railing and straightened and pulled the hood up in the

automatic way of someone who put the hood up without thinking about it, which made the gesture a habit rather than a concealment, which meant it was armour of a different kind. "I need to go. There is something in the western part of the district tonight. I felt it earlier."

"A Wraith?" Bás Eagla said.

"Something feeding. Not a major one. But it should be handled." He looked at them both. "Thank you for coming. I did not think I would say that, but I do."

He walked off the bridge and into the city.

Within thirty seconds he was gone, not dramatically but practically, simply absorbed into the fabric of the district the way water was absorbed into ground.

Bás Eagla watched the space where he had been.

Through The Mind, he felt the presence moving west through the city, quick and purposeful, and he felt, slightly ahead of it and slightly above, something else. A different quality of presence. Not living, not constructed, not spiritual in the way the mansion's spirits had been. Something that ate emotions. Something that had been eating them for a while.

Then both presences were too far to read, and the canal was just a canal, and the city was just a city.

"Well," Zephyr said.

"Well," Bás Eagla agreed.

They walked back through Shinjuku in the evening, following no particular route, and the city did what cities did at this hour, which was become something different from what it had been during the day, not quieter exactly but differently loud, the commercial noise replaced by the residential kind, the purposeful movement replaced by the wandering kind.

Zephyr walked with his hands behind his head and looked at the signs and the lights and the people and the spaces between all of those things with the open, uncomplicated attention of someone who found the world genuinely interesting and had never seen a reason to pretend otherwise.

Bás Eagla walked beside him and thought about the bridge.

"He grew up in places where nobody asked," he said, after a while.

Zephyr lowered his hands. He looked at Bás Eagla without saying anything.

"He asks everyone else," Bás Eagla said. "The hardware shop woman. Whoever else he moves among. He asks because it seemed like something that should happen more." He was quiet for a moment. "He has been alone with the Wraiths for years and he spent that time making sure to ask the people around him if they were all right."

Zephyr walked beside him.

"It is a particular kind of person," he said, "who survives something difficult and decides the lesson is to be more attentive to other people."

Bás Eagla looked at the lights of the city ahead of them.

"Yes," he said. "It is."

They walked on, and the city continued around them, and above it somewhere a young man in a hooded jacket was moving through the dark toward something that fed on fear, which he had been doing alone for a long time and would continue to do, at least for now, but which was not quite as alone as it had been an hour ago, in the small and specific way that a contact number was not alone.

Zephyr stopped walking.

Bás Eagla stopped beside him.

They were at an intersection, no particular intersection, the kind that cities produced in their thousands, and Zephyr was looking at a small restaurant

across the street with the specific quality of attention he gave to things that interested him.

"We are in Japan," he said.

"We are," Bás Eagla said.

"We were here before," Zephyr said. "And we said we would go to a izakaya when we were done. And we did."

"We did," Bás Eagla said.

Zephyr looked at him.

"We are done," he said. "With the last contact. All seven."

"We are done with the last contact," Bás Eagla agreed.

"So," Zephyr said.

Bás Eagla looked at the small restaurant across the street. Through the window, which was the kind of window that fogged slightly from the warmth inside, the light was warm and the people at the counter were eating something.

"We are not going home yet," he said.

"No," Zephyr said. "We are not going home yet."

"There is a report to file," Bás Eagla said. "On Greece. The intake processing for Ravi is not complete. There is a follow-up required on Kael. There is the question of the field contact rotation for Goroeth that needs to be arranged through the ISP office." He paused. "There is also the question of Morganna's check-in, which as I predicted she has not done."

"She absolutely has not done it," Zephyr agreed.

"All of that requires attention before we return to base."

"It does," Zephyr said.

They looked at each other across the intersection.

"But," Bás Eagla said, "none of it requires attention tonight."

Zephyr's mask shifted into something that was, for his mask, very close to quiet happiness.

"No," he said. "None of it requires attention tonight."

They crossed the street.

Chapter Nine

THE VEILED QUEEN

The restaurant was small and the counter was warm and the menu had more items on it than Bás Eagla would have chosen from on his own, and Zephyr was reading it with the focused joy of a man who had been handed something that required genuine decision-making.

"The skewered pork," he said.

"You said that already."

"I am reaffirming it. I am also considering the tofu."

"You do not usually consider the tofu."

"Japan changes a person." Zephyr set the menu down and looked at the counter, at the two men cooking behind it with the practiced efficiency of people who had been doing this for a long time and had arrived at a version of the work that was both fast and unhurried. "This is good," he said. "Being here. Sitting here."

"Yes," Bás Eagla said.

"We have had a long week."

"We have had a long several days, yes."

"The whole trip." Zephyr looked at the fogged window and the city beyond it, which was doing the thing cities did at this hour, which was be alive in the unhurried way of a place that had plenty of night left. "Seven contacts. One went through a wall. One set an eighteen-day ambush and sent a sniper."

"He was not in our file at all," Bás Eagla said.

"He was not in our file at all," Zephyr agreed. "And one had a bear." He paused. "The bear was the best part."

"You said that on the way out of Sweden."

"I am still saying it."

The door of the restaurant opened.

Bás Eagla was facing the counter and felt it rather than saw it, felt the specific quality of the person who came in, which was the quality of someone moving fast and not for reasons of ordinary urgency. He turned on the stool.

Ethan Blackwood stood in the doorway of the restaurant with his hood up and his breathing elevated and an expression on his face that was the expression of someone who had followed two ISP agents across Shinjuku to a restaurant they had gone to and was aware this was not how the evening was supposed to have continued.

He looked at them. They looked at him.

"You followed us," Zephyr said.

"Yes," Ethan said.

"To the restaurant."

"Yes." He was scanning the room, the windows, the street outside, in the specific way of someone whose awareness of the world was structured around threats. "Something is wrong. Something is coming. In the western district, where I said I was going." He paused. "It is not the Wraith I felt earlier. It is something much larger. Something is controlling them. I have felt Wraiths for years and I have never felt anything like whatever is behind this. It is not natural. It is not the kind of movement Wraiths make on their own." He looked at Bás Eagla directly. "I turned around because you said your ability might register them. And because whatever this is, it is too large for one person."

The two men behind the counter continued cooking. Outside the window, the city moved.

Then an explosion sounded from the western district. Not loud, not close, but real, the deep thud of something structural giving way, and through the restaurant window the glow of it was visible above the rooflines for three seconds before it faded.

Zephyr set the menu down.

"How large?" Bás Eagla said, already standing.

"Large enough that I came back," Ethan said.

Bás Eagla extended The Mind outward and found, immediately, what had not been there twenty minutes ago: a disturbance in the western part of the district that did not read as the lateral, old spiritual texture of Morganna's mansion or the quick mischief of Wisp and Glum. This was something else. Something vast and cold and moving with a deliberateness that was not the movement of things that simply existed but the movement of something that was being directed. Dozens of points, each one a presence of the type he had barely registered when Ethan was walking west, but gathered now, organised, densely, moving through the city in a pattern that had structure.

And behind all of them, at the centre of the pattern, something else. Something that The Mind touched and immediately registered as too large to read fully, the way you could not read a room by standing inside it.

He had never felt anything like it.

"We are going," he said.

The western part of the district was two streets different from the rest of it when they arrived, which was how you knew something was wrong before you saw anything specific. The difference was the people. Not a crowd, not a panic, but the specific thinning of pedestrian traffic that happened when the body decided, without consulting the brain, that a direction was wrong. People were moving away from the western streets without quite knowing why, and the ones who had stopped to check their phones or look around had the

expression of people trying to account for something their senses had logged and their reason had not yet processed.

"They can feel them," Ethan said, walking quickly at Bás Eagla's left. "Not see them. Just feel them. The Wraiths produce something, a frequency or a pressure, something that the body responds to even when the eyes don't register the source. Most people feel it as unease and attribute it to something else."

"How many?" Bás Eagla asked.

"More than I have seen in one place before." Ethan's voice was even but the evenness was the practiced kind. "Forty. Possibly more. They are not feeding yet, they are moving. They are being moved."

"By what?"

"I do not know. I have never seen Wraiths controlled before. They are drawn to negative emotion, they cluster around it, but they do not take orders. This is different." He paused. "There is something at the centre of the district. Whatever it is, it is the reason they are moving."

Bás Eagla could feel it too, now, from this distance, more clearly than from the restaurant. The centre of the pattern was approximately three streets ahead and to the north, and the quality of it through The Mind was the quality of something that had been in the world for a very long time and moved through it the way old things moved, with the certainty of something that expected the world to accommodate it rather than the other way around.

"Zephyr," he said.

"I know," Zephyr said, from his right. His suit had settled into its battle cycling, the colours moving faster than they did in ordinary circumstances. His hands were at his sides and he was reading the street ahead with the alert, forward attention of someone who had been in enough situations to know when the situation was starting.

They turned the corner and found it starting.

The Wraiths were not visible to Bás Eagla or to Zephyr.

This was the fundamental problem and it established itself immediately.

What they could see was the effect: a parked vehicle thirty metres ahead lurching sideways as if struck by something that was not there, a shopfront window spidering into cracks from an impact with no visible source, a man on the pavement going down hard with his arms over his head in the reflexive protection of someone being struck from a direction he could not identify. The Wraiths were moving through the street and they were moving with purpose and the people on the street were responding to impacts and forces from sources they could not see, which was a specific kind of terror because it removed all the ordinary calculations of distance and response.

Ethan stopped. His face changed.

"There are twelve in this street," he said. "Six ahead, four on the left flank, two at the far end. They are moving the people away from the central street. They are clearing it."

"Can you stop them?" Zephyr asked.

Ethan's expression did something complicated. "I can see them. I can track them. I can repel individual Wraiths with the right approach. This many, organised like this, I cannot."

"All right," Bás Eagla said. "You tell us where they are. I will use the Nightmares. If I can locate them through The Mind and you can confirm position, I can reach them."

Ethan pointed. "Two metres ahead of you and one and a half to the left. Standing."

Bás Eagla aimed the Nightmare ability at the coordinates and pushed.

Something happened. He felt it through The Mind, the lateral spiritual presence at those coordinates convulsing, recoiling, and then there was a

sound that was not quite sound, a frequency at the lower edge of audible that made the air feel briefly wrong, and the parked vehicle ahead stopped moving.

"It worked," Ethan said, with the specific relief of someone who had been doing something alone for a long time and had just seen the available options change.

"Next one," Bás Eagla said.

For the next four minutes, it worked.

Ethan called positions. Bás Eagla aimed the Nightmare ability at each coordinate in sequence, and each contact produced the same result: a Wraith driven back or dispersed or at minimum disrupted enough to stop its current action. Zephyr handled the secondary effects, moving people out of the path of impacts they could not see coming, positioning himself as a barrier between the street's remaining civilians and directions from which force was arriving.

It was not elegant. It was functional, the specific functionality of people who had just found an approach and were applying it as fast as they could before the conditions changed.

The conditions changed.

The first sign was Ethan going very still.

The second sign was the light.

It appeared at the far end of the street, at the central intersection the Wraiths had been clearing, and it was not the light of anything that belonged in a Tokyo street at night. It was magenta, vivid and wrong, the colour of something that existed in a register adjacent to the visible spectrum and was only partly located in the world they were standing in. It moved with it, the light, moved as if it were liquid, dripping from the edges of the figure it outlined as the figure came around the corner and into the street.

Nimlaser was tall. The armour she wore was alive the way the Wraiths were alive, shifting and rippling at the edges, serrated and organic, the darkness of it and the magenta of it alternating as she moved. Twin horns rose from her head in the silhouette of something ancient and intentional. Her face was below the curtain of pitch-black hair, and from the space beneath it something glowed, faint, red, in the way eyes glowed when they were not human eyes.

She was already drawing the sword.

The dark crystal of it caught no light because it produced its own, the sinister pulse of it, and the Wraiths in the street that Bás Eagla had been disrupting one by one reoriented toward her and then immediately back toward the three of them, and this time there was no pause in the reorientation, no recalibration delay. The command was instant and the response was instant.

"What is that," Zephyr said.

"I do not know," Bás Eagla said. He pushed The Mind toward her and found something he had not encountered before, a presence that was both enormous and specifically shielded, ancient and deep, the shield of something that had spent centuries becoming difficult to read. He could feel the edges of her. He could not feel the interior. "She is not in any file. She controls the Wraiths." He looked at Ethan. "Did you know this was possible?"

"No," Ethan said, very quietly. He was looking at her with an expression Bás Eagla could not categorise. "I have studied Wraiths for years. I did not know this was possible."

Then Nimlaser looked at them.

Not the general surveying look of someone arriving. A direct, specific look, the look of something that had already decided what it was going to do and was now telling them so.

She raised the sword and every Wraith in the street moved at once.

What followed was not a fight in the way the fights on this trip had been fights.

The Bone-Gears had been a machine with configurations and a pilot who was delighted to be testing it. Kael had been a professional doing a job. Boulder had been an animal defending a home. Even Ravi, coming through a wall on fire, had been a person looking for someone she loved.

This was different.

The Wraiths arrived without warning because they had no bodies to track, no footsteps, no displaced air, no sound of approach. Ethan was the only one who could see them and he was calling positions as fast as he could, his voice doing the work of a second sense for two people who did not have the first one:

"Left, one metre, high. Behind you, ground level. Three at the far end, moving fast. One at the building on your right, it's going for the window."

Bás Eagla worked from the coordinates, using the Nightmare ability in rapid sequence, each one requiring a targeting effort he normally did not have to make consciously because he could see his targets. Aiming at a point in space based on someone else's description while simultaneously maintaining awareness of everything else in the environment was a different kind of demand. He was managing it but the margin was narrowing from the first second.

Zephyr was handling the physical. The impacts the Wraiths produced, the objects they moved, the surfaces they struck, the people they pushed toward. He could not fight them directly but he could stand between them and the consequences, and he was doing this with the controlled momentum of the Freight Train, his suit cycling to its brightest sequence in the hope that the light disrupted the Wraiths' movement the way it disrupted things that tracked visually. From Ethan's reactions, it was having some effect. Not much.

And through all of it, Nimlaser walked.

She did not run, she did not rush, she simply walked up the street toward them, and her walking had the quality of something that was not hurrying because it did not need to hurry, and the sword moved in slow arcs beside her

that cut the visible air and left behind them the cold absence of a doorway, and through each cut a new Wraith emerged.

She was generating them as she moved.

"There are too many," Ethan said, from behind a vehicle they were using as a partial barrier. His voice had not broken but it was carrying the weight of someone whose real-time assessment was not finding the numbers good. "I can call them but you cannot take them all out fast enough. Whatever is directing them is compensating between your strikes. And she keeps making more."

Bás Eagla knew this. He could feel it through The Mind, the pattern adjusting each time he disrupted a node, the gaps filling in time with the new arrivals from the cuts, and the thing directing it was not operating on instinct but on intelligence, watching his interventions and adjusting for them faster than he could adjust back.

The shop drew his attention through The Mind.

A concentration of Wraith activity at a building to the east, off the main street, the hardware shop closed for the evening but whose owner lived in the apartment above it. Three Wraiths at the window, working on whatever was on the other side.

"Go," Zephyr said.

He moved toward Nimlaser directly, the straightforward commitment of something that had decided the most useful thing it could do was disrupt the directing intelligence. His suit flared to maximum brightness as he moved, a flash that bleached the colour from the street, and the Wraiths nearest to him recoiled from it, not dispersed but pushed back, and in the gap Zephyr covered the distance fast.

Nimlaser watched him come.

She did not move.

She raised the sword when he was three metres away and the arc it made was not aimed at him, it was aimed at the ground beside him, and what came through the cut that it left in the street was not a Wraith but something else, something that erupted upward, dark flame in violet, eldritch and wrong, and it hit Zephyr's left side with a force that was not physical and was not the Wraith impacts he had been absorbing all evening.

It drained.

That was the only word for it. It hit him and something went out of him, not blood, not visible damage, but the specific quality of Zephyr's relentless, inexhaustible presence dimmed for a moment, and for the first time on this trip Zephyr made a sound that was not commentary or strategy but the involuntary sound of something encountering a force it did not have a prepared response to.

He kept moving. He was Zephyr and he kept moving. But the movement was different.

Bás Eagla shadow-stepped to the hardware shop.

The interior was dark and the Wraiths were inside it and he felt them through The Mind, three presences moving up the staircase toward the apartment above. He aimed and pushed the Nightmare into the staircase at all three coordinates simultaneously, which was at the edge of what the ability could do when it had already been used for the duration of the engagement in the street, and the result was not clean: two recoiled and one continued, and from the floor above came the involuntary sound of a person registering that something was wrong in the room with them.

He went up the stairs.

He found the hardware shop owner standing in her kitchen, having come to look at whatever she had heard, which was the worst possible position. The Wraith was between her and the window and Ethan was calling its position from the doorway and Bás Eagla aimed and pushed and the Nightmare hit and

the kitchen window cracked outward from the recoil, and she took one step back and grabbed the counter.

Not hurt. Not touched.

She looked at the cracked window and then at Bás Eagla in his skull mask and his war robe and she did the very rapid calculation of an intelligent and practical woman.

"You should leave the building," Bás Eagla said. "Take the back exit. Go to the nearest hotel and stay inside."

She looked at him for a moment.

"Are you all right?" she said.

He was not expecting the question. It arrived with the same quality it had had in Ethan's account of asking it, offered without expectation of return.

"Please leave the building," he said.

She left. He heard her on the back stairs, quick and purposeful.

He turned back to the door and ran.

The street had changed while he was in the shop.

He felt it before he cleared the door: the specific quality of a situation that had moved past the phase where management was sufficient. Through The Mind he found Zephyr and found what Zephyr was experiencing, and it was not what Zephyr usually experienced in an engagement, which was the ordinary functional demands of being large and fast and impenetrable. The dark flame had hit him twice more in the time Bás Eagla had been in the shop, he could read the marks of it even through The Mind, and each hit had taken something that was not structural but was essential, and the Zephyr he found through The Mind was present but quieter, and quieter was not a word that applied to Zephyr under ordinary circumstances.

Nimlaser had moved up the street.

She was thirty metres closer than she had been when he left. The sword was active and producing the violet flame in controlled arcs, and the Wraiths she had been generating throughout the engagement were now sufficient in number that Ethan's calling had become fragmented, too many positions shifting too fast to track as separate coordinates, his voice arriving in shorter bursts with longer gaps between them.

"I cannot keep up with them," Ethan said. He said it without self-judgment, the plain assessment of someone who had hit the limit of what a specific ability could do against a specific scale of opposition. "They are moving faster than I can call them. There are too many and they are not staying in one position long enough."

Bás Eagla pushed the Nightmare ability at the nearest cluster of Wraith presences he could feel through The Mind without Ethan's guidance, using The Mind's raw perception rather than Ethan's confirmation, and hit two, and the ability reached its sustained limit in the same moment, thinning past the point where thinning was manageable, not gone but slow, the way a muscle failed, and the two Wraiths he had disrupted reorganised in the time the recovery took.

He had been doing this for too long without pause.

The Veil of Fear arrived.

It was not directed. It radiated from Nimlaser outward through the street in all directions, and what it produced in the people still on the street was the specific response of bodies encountering something that their deepest architecture recognised as wrong. Several people sat down where they were standing. One ran. Several others froze.

What it produced in Bás Eagla was different.

The Veil touched The Mind and The Mind registered it and the thing it tried to produce in him was a nightmare, which was his own domain, and the contact

of something that worked the way his own ability worked but arriving from outside was disorienting in a way that the Bone-Gears and Ravi and even Kael's headshot had not been. His mind protection activated, the passive reflex of his own architecture, and the nightmare the Veil tried to construct turned, and the turning sent it back.

Nimlaser received it.

She made a sound. Brief, not loud. The sound of something that had not expected to receive what it sent.

And then she looked at him, and the red glow beneath the hair intensified.

What came next was not the Veil and was not the Wraiths and was not the dark flame. She raised the sword and brought it down in an arc that was aimed not at him specifically but at the ground between them, and the cut it left was wider than any of the cuts she had made before, wide enough to walk through, and the cold that came through it was not temperature, it was the cold of somewhere else entirely pressing against the edge of the here and now, and three spectral knights came through, not Wraiths, something different, armoured in tattered remnants and wielding weapons forged from shadow, and they moved with the coordinated silence of something bound to a single will.

The Umbral Guard.

"Zephyr," Bás Eagla said.

Zephyr was already dealing with one of them, because there were three and Ethan had tried to repel one and the repelling had not worked the way it worked on ordinary Wraiths, and the knight he had approached had passed through his effort and struck him, and Ethan went down, not out, but down, on one knee with his hand on the pavement, head up, still functioning but breathing hard.

Zephyr put himself between the knight and Ethan with the instinct of someone who did not calculate this kind of decision. The knight hit him with a

shadow weapon and the dark flame was on the weapon and the combination of it hit Zephyr the way the previous strikes had hit him, and Zephyr moved back one step, two steps, and did not go down, but the step backward was the most significant thing Zephyr had done all evening because Zephyr did not step backward.

Bás Eagla became intangible and went through the nearest knight, came out the other side, put shadow constructs around its legs and collapsed them, and the knight went down and stayed down, but the constructs cost him the same capacity the Nightmare ability had been costing him and the pool was not deep enough for both.

He looked at Nimlaser.

She was twenty metres away. The sword was in her hand. The Wraiths had closed the perimeter of the street completely, forty of them in a ring that had not been there when the fight started and that Ethan could not repel and that Bás Eagla could not take apart fast enough with the ability running at the rate it currently was. Zephyr was absorbing what the dark flame was doing to him and continuing to function but the continuation was costing him more with each exchange. Ethan was back on his feet but he was operating in a space that was above his scale and he knew it and he was staying functional through will rather than capacity.

The second knight came at Bás Eagla from the left.

He shadow-stepped and the Nightmare ability, reaching for its last functional output, hit the knight and slowed it, and slow was not stopped, and the knight's weapon came through his intangibility because it was a shadow weapon and shadow weapons did not interact with Umbral Intangibility the way physical weapons did, and what hit him was not force but the same draining quality the dark flame had, and it hit him in the chest and something in the careful architecture of the abilities he had been maintaining throughout the evening went out of alignment.

He was solid again before he intended to be.

He was on one knee.

He was aware of this as a fact rather than as a crisis, which was the specific quality of a mind that had been trained to keep processing even when the body had made a decision the mind had not authorised. He assessed: Zephyr was standing but compromised. Ethan was standing but at his limit. The Nightmare ability was at the edge of its sustainable range. The shadow constructs were available but slow. The Wraith ring was complete.

Nimlaser was standing in the middle of the street, ten metres away, and the red glow beneath the hair was steady and patient, and she was looking at him with the look she had given him when the Veil returned to her, specific, assessing, adding him to something she was building an understanding of.

She was not done.

She raised the sword.

Zephyr moved. Not toward Nimlaser, toward Bás Eagla, putting himself between, which was the geometry of someone who had made the only decision available to them and was not interested in reviewing it, and the dark flame came off the sword's arc and hit Zephyr full across the chest and this time Zephyr went down to one knee too, and the two of them were on the pavement in the street in Tokyo with the Wraith ring closed around them and Nimlaser's sword raised and the city continuing its indifferent city business on the other side of everything.

Ethan stood between them and her.

It was not a strategic decision. He did not have anything left that was strategic. He stood there because the other option was not standing there and that was not the kind of person he was, and he looked at the Veiled Queen with the dark brown eyes of someone who was running on the specific fuel of people who had been running on empty for so long they had stopped noticing.

Nimlaser looked at all three of them.

The sword was still raised.

The street was very quiet.

Chapter Ten

THE TRIUMPHANT TRINITY

The sword was still raised.

Nimlaser looked at all three of them with the patient red glow of something that had been patient for a very long time and found patience easy, and the Wraith ring was complete and the Umbral Guard were still in the street and Ethan was standing between her and Bás Eagla and Zephyr with nothing left but the decision to stand there, which was enough for him but was not, mathematically, sufficient.

She began to lower the sword toward Ethan.

Something hit her from the left at a speed that made the arrival simultaneous with the departure, a kinetic impact that had no visible source until the source was already four metres past her and decelerating, and Nimlaser stumbled one step to the right, which she had not done once in the entire engagement, and the sword's arc went wide.

"Good evening," said a voice from the far end of the street, bright and slightly breathless with the specific breathlessness of someone who had covered a significant distance in a very short time and was managing the deceleration.

"Sorry I am late. The flight was delayed, then I ran the rest, there was some confusion about which district, I passed this street twice, which is embarrassing at my speed, but I am here now and I want to say that whatever has been happening here looks extremely serious and I am going to need someone to brief me, ideally not while being attacked."

He was lean and athletic in a silver-blue suit that still had the faint light-streaks of recent velocity along its surface, a visor across his eyes, tousled dark hair visible at his temples. He was standing at the far end of the street with the relaxed posture of someone whose relationship with danger had always been mediated by the fact that he could leave it faster than it could follow, and he was looking at the Wraith ring around the street with the

expression of someone who could not see what was in it and was aware he could not see what was in it and was moving anyway.

He moved again.

The second hit came from behind Nimlaser, the third from her right, the fourth from a direction that was not quite either, and each one landed and was gone before the visual processing could catch it, and the speed of them was not Zephyr's Freight Train momentum but something else, something that operated at a register where the impact and the departure were grammatically the same event. The Wraiths in the ring could not track him. He could not see them either, but he was moving fast enough that the distinction between tracking and not tracking became academic when everything in your path was moving through you before it had time to react.

Nimlaser turned.

The red glow beneath the hair was not patient now. Something behind it had changed quality, the way a fire changed quality when it was fed oxygen it had not expected.

She raised the sword toward where the speedster had last been, which was not where he currently was, and the dark crystal arc cut empty air, and the cut it left behind opened on nothing because he was not there.

"Where is he?" she said, and her voice was the first time she had spoken, a haunting echo of something that lived in the space between sounds, and the three of them on the pavement heard it and Ethan heard it, and the quality of it was not rage but its colder and more ancient equivalent.

"Everywhere," Velocity Vanguard said, from a different part of the street, and hit her again.

Then the Umbral Guard moved toward him and the mathematics changed.

The shadow knights were not Wraiths and were not subject to the same limitations. They tracked by something other than visual processing and they

tracked him through the turns, and the first one's weapon came close enough that the visor cracked at the edge, and Velocity Vanguard pulled back to the far end of the street with the expression of someone updating their assessment.

"The armoured ones can follow me," he said, to no one in particular. "Noted."

Then the street's ambient light changed.

It changed in the way it changed when someone applied significant psychic pressure to the immediate environment, a shimmer in the visible field that was not quite light and not quite the absence of it, and the Wraith ring buckled.

Not broke. Buckled. From the outside, as if something had pressed against it from the perimeter and found the formation's structural weaknesses and applied force at precisely the right points, and three of the Wraiths at the ring's eastern edge scattered, and through the gap that created came a man who was walking.

He was perhaps fifty, Italian in appearance, olive skin and salt-and-pepper hair impeccably maintained, a tailored suit that belonged in a different context than a damaged Tokyo street at night. He was slightly portly and he carried himself with the absolute authority of someone who had not needed to announce his arrival since approximately the second decade of his life. His crystal-blue eyes moved across the street with the specific quality of a person reading a room and the room in question being the interior of every mind it contained.

He looked at Nimlaser.

He looked at the sword.

He looked at Ethan, who was still standing between the Veiled Queen and two people on the pavement who were getting back up.

He raised one hand and the force field assembled around Ethan without visible mechanism, a shimmering architecture of psychic energy that enclosed

him and communicated to the sword and to everything else in the street that this person was no longer an available target.

"Velocity," Ultramind said. His voice was conversational, with the unhurried clarity of someone who projected at exactly the volume required and no more. "The large ones. Keep them moving."

"On it," said Velocity Vanguard, already gone.

What followed had the quality of a different kind of fight from what had come before.

The first fight had been three people applying everything they had to a problem that outscaled everything they had, and losing incrementally.

This was not that.

Ultramind did not engage Nimlaser directly. He engaged the Wraiths, which he also could not see, but which he did not need to see because he could feel them through the psychic field the way Bás Eagla felt them through The Mind, and the Nightmare ability and the psychic ability were not the same thing but they were adjacent things, and when Bás Eagla felt Ultramind's awareness moving through the Wraith ring he felt something that was not his own ability and was not incompatible with it.

"The northeast cluster," Bás Eagla said, getting to one knee. "Eight metres. They are condensed."

Ultramind looked northeast and the telekinetic pressure he applied to the condensed cluster was not targeted the way the Nightmare had been, it was broad and sustained, the force of it folding the Wraiths out of their formation and dispersing them against the ring's own perimeter, which weakened the ring at the point where the dispersal happened, and Velocity Vanguard was already at that point, hitting the Umbral Guard that had moved to close it.

"The guard on the left leads with the right arm," Velocity Vanguard said, having assessed this at a velocity that made assessment and action the same

thing. "The shoulder is the hinge. If you freeze the shoulder it cannot finish the swing."

Ultramind froze the shoulder. The guard's swing stopped mid-arc and Velocity Vanguard went through the gap and the guard went down.

Bás Eagla was on his feet.

The Nightmare ability had not recovered to full capacity but it had recovered to functional, the way a muscle recovered when it was allowed a moment rather than a minute, and functional was sufficient for what the new configuration of the fight required, which was not him carrying the full weight alone but him as one part of a structure that distributed the weight differently.

He used it on the Wraiths Ultramind's telekinesis had scattered, catching them individually in the dispersed state before they could regroup, and each one he disrupted was a node the formation could not rebuild from, and the ring that had been complete was now a ring with gaps, and a ring with gaps was a different thing from a ring without them.

Nimlaser understood this.

She had been watching the fight reorganise around her with the red glow steady and her sword at her side, and the quality of what she was watching had shifted, he could feel it through The Mind, from the patient assessment of something winning to the colder assessment of something calculating cost. She raised the sword and opened a cut in the air and three new Wraiths came through and she directed them at Ultramind, because Ultramind was the structural centre of the new formation, and removing him would return the fight to what it had been.

The Wraiths reached him at speed.

They also, somehow, did not reach him.

The lead Wraith was three metres from Ultramind when it slowed, not because Ultramind had done anything visible, not because the psychic field had pushed it, but simply because something in its path had impeded it in a

way that produced no evidence of impeding. It recovered and moved again and slowed again and the second Wraith moved around the first and encountered the same resistance, and Ultramind continued working the northeast cluster with the undivided attention of someone who was not aware of being protected.

He might have been, actually. But he gave no sign.

Nimlaser's sword arm dropped fractionally.

Just fractionally. A degree. The degree of something encountering a variable it cannot account for.

Then Velocity Vanguard hit the remaining Umbral Guard from three directions at speeds that the shadow knights, with all their non-visual tracking, could not divide between simultaneously, and two of them went down and the third turned to follow him and its foot caught nothing that was visible in the street and it went to one knee and stayed there, and the sword Velocity Vanguard threw at it from across the street, which he had found in the wreckage of the street's earlier damage, pinned its shadow armour to the pavement and held it.

The Wraith ring was gone.

The Umbral Guard were down.

The new Wraiths Nimlaser had generated were disrupted.

She stood in the middle of the street with the magenta light dripping from her armour and the sword in her hand and five people facing her at various distances, and the cold accounting behind the red glow ran its numbers, and the numbers were different now from what they had been.

She looked at Bás Eagla.

The look was specific. It had a quality he had not encountered before, not from any of the contacts on this trip, not from any opponent he had faced. It was

the look of something entering him into a category that it was going to return to.

Then she raised the sword and cut a portal in the air behind her, vertical and dark and opening on somewhere that was not the street, and the magenta light pulled back toward her and the remaining shadows gathered and she stepped backward through it.

The portal closed.

The street was ordinary again.

It was very, very quiet.

Velocity Vanguard let out a breath.

"Okay," he said. "That was a serious situation."

Ultramind walked through the damaged street toward Bás Eagla and Zephyr and Ethan with the measured pace of someone who was running a post-engagement assessment and producing it internally. He looked at the three of them in turn with the crystal-blue eyes that Bás Eagla recognised from the file, the eyes that were not simply observant but were doing something more than observing.

He stopped in front of them.

"You held for longer than most would have," he said. He said it without condescension, as a fact.

"We had enough warning to get the civilians out," Bás Eagla said. "That was the priority."

Ultramind looked at him for a moment with the specific quality of someone who was not reading a mind but was noting something about its architecture.

"Yes," he said. "I can see that it was."

Velocity Vanguard had arrived at a speed that, for him, constituted a casual approach, and was looking at Zephyr with the uncomplicated appreciation of someone encountering something new.

"You are very large," he said.

"Yes," Zephyr said.

"And you glow."

"Also yes."

"The suit, is it without thermal output? My visor is showing your thermal signature as absent."

"Something like that."

Velocity Vanguard nodded with the enthusiasm of someone filing this information in a category he found genuinely exciting. He turned to Ethan.

"You," he said. "You were the one holding position at the end. With nothing to hold it with."

Ethan looked at him. "Someone had to."

"Yes," Velocity Vanguard said, with a simplicity that was not dismissive.

"Someone always does. That is usually how we find people worth knowing."

Bás Eagla looked at the two of them.

He had read the ISP's international file on the Triumphant Trinity three months ago, a brief and largely speculative document assembled from field reports and secondhand accounts. He had noted them as an organisation of interest and filed them under entities whose cooperation might at some point be valuable. He had not expected them in a Tokyo street at close to midnight.

"The ISP has a file on you," he said to Ultramind.

"I know," Ultramind said. "It is mostly inaccurate. I allowed it to remain inaccurate because accurate files have a way of attracting attention I prefer not

to attract." He paused. "You are Bás Eagla. Your partner is Zephyr. The file the Trinity keeps on the ISP's Base 45 is somewhat better sourced than the reverse."

"You have a file on us," Zephyr said.

"On the ISP generally. Your names came up in relation to several incidents that crossed into our operational area." Ultramind looked at Ethan. "This one was not in any of our files. But we monitor Wraith activity as part of ongoing research. What happened tonight was the largest Wraith event ever recorded in a single location. It triggered every sensor we have pointed at this region."

"What was she?" Bás Eagla asked.

Ultramind was quiet for a moment. It was not the quiet of someone who did not know. It was the quiet of someone deciding how much of what they knew was appropriate to say in a damaged Tokyo street at midnight.

"Something very old," he said. "Something that has been managing this city's Wraith population for longer than the city has existed. We have records of her going back several hundred years under various names. We did not know she was active in this capacity. Tonight is the first time she has engaged directly with anyone rather than operating through the Wraiths."

"She was assessing us," Bás Eagla said.

"Yes. Which means she will be back." Ultramind looked at the intersection where the portal had been. "But not tonight. Whatever the assessment produced, she requires time to act on it."

Zephyr looked at Ethan. Ethan looked at the street. The street looked like what it was, which was a street in Tokyo where something significant had happened and which would, in the morning, confuse everyone who had to explain the damage.

Zephyr looked at Ultramind and Velocity Vanguard.

"There are two of you," he said.

"Yes," Velocity Vanguard said.

"You are called the Triumphant Trinity."

A pause.

Velocity Vanguard and Ultramind looked at each other with the specific look of people who had been asked this before and had the answer prepared and did not entirely enjoy giving it.

"The Trinity was founded by three people," Ultramind said. "The third was our leader. Her name was Afyabalqis. She founded the organisation, she built what we are, and she disappeared without warning during an operation fourteen months ago." He looked at the street. "We have not found her. We have not stopped looking. We keep the name because the name was hers and what she built deserves to outlast her disappearance. Until we know otherwise, we maintain the hope that it is a disappearance and not something more final." He paused. "The Trinity was three people when it mattered most. It remains the Trinity."

The word settled between them.

Velocity Vanguard looked at his boots for a moment. Then he looked up with the expression of someone who had decided, as he always decided, that the way forward was forward.

"She would have liked you two," he said, to Bás Eagla and Zephyr. "She had a very specific appreciation for people who were doing the right thing in very strange circumstances. You would have been her kind of people."

Bás Eagla did not respond to this immediately.

"I read about her," he said, after a moment. "In the file."

"Then you know more about her than most," Velocity Vanguard said. "She was not someone who left a large record. She preferred it that way."

They stood in the street for a while longer, all five of them, and the Tokyo night continued around them, and eventually Ultramind produced something from his jacket that looked like a communication device and began coordinating with someone who was apparently already handling the question of how to explain the damage to the relevant municipal authorities, which suggested the Trinity had infrastructure for exactly this kind of aftermath.

Ethan sat down on a low concrete barrier at the street's edge and looked at the city.

Velocity Vanguard sat next to him. Not close, not invasive, just present, the way someone sat next to a person who had held position at the end of a fight with nothing to hold it with.

Zephyr sat next to Bás Eagla on the pavement, which was not an elegant place to sit but was available and neither of them was interested in elegance at this particular moment.

"She is going to come back," Zephyr said.

"Yes," Bás Eagla said.

"And we are not going to be able to handle it alone."

"We did not handle it alone tonight."

Zephyr looked at the portal space. "No. We did not."

Bás Eagla looked at Ultramind, who was communicating efficiently with whoever was on the other end of the device and was also, Bás Eagla suspected, monitoring approximately four other things simultaneously. He looked at Velocity Vanguard, who was saying something to Ethan that was producing in Ethan the specific quality of expression of someone receiving the thing they did not know they needed to hear.

"We have a report to file," Bás Eagla said.

"We do."

"An extensive one."

"Very."

"It is going to generate significant institutional interest."

"Probably the most significant report Base 45 has filed in some time," Zephyr agreed.

"And then," Bás Eagla said, "we are going to need to talk to the Trinity about what comes next."

Zephyr nodded slowly.

"Tomorrow," he said.

"Tomorrow," Bás Eagla agreed.

"Tonight," Zephyr said, looking at the restaurant they had left less than an hour ago, whose window was still fogged from the inside and whose counter was still warm, "we were in the middle of something."

Bás Eagla looked at the restaurant.

"The skewered pork," he said.

"And the tofu," Zephyr said. "I had decided on the tofu."

Bás Eagla stood. Zephyr stood beside him.

"Ultramind," Bás Eagla said.

The Italian looked up from the device.

"The restaurant across the street is still open. You and your colleague are welcome to join us while we wait for the situation to be contained."

Ultramind looked at him for a moment with the crystal-blue eyes that were always doing more than looking.

"Yes," he said. "I think we will."

Velocity Vanguard was already on his feet. "Is it good?" he said, looking at the restaurant. "It looks good. It smells good. I can smell it from here, my senses are enhanced, everything about this situation suggests it is good."

"We had not yet ordered when the evening became complicated," Bás Eagla said.

"Then we are all finding out together," Velocity Vanguard said, with the uncomplicated optimism of someone for whom this was a perfectly good way to end a night, and he went through the door.

Ethan looked at the restaurant. Then he looked at Bás Eagla.

"You are not going home," he said.

"Not yet," Bás Eagla said.

Ethan looked at the city, the Tokyo night, the undamaged parts of it and the damaged parts of it, the lights and the canals and the rooftops he knew and the streets below them he had moved through for years.

"I know a place," he said, "that does better tofu than that restaurant."

Zephyr looked at him.

"Show us," he said.

Aftermath

Jesús, El Salvador

He started sending the ISP's monthly contact prompt back before anyone came to find him the following month. He did not acknowledge the change. The ISP did not comment on it. His mother's apartment had a new lock on the door, installed by someone who was good with his hands and had left no note about it. The gold wing and the black wing could be seen over the San

Salvador skyline on clear evenings, a little higher than strictly necessary, as if the city looked different from altitude and was worth looking at.

Tyrell "Iron Heart" Mason, New York

He called. He called on the scheduled day, at the scheduled time, with the brevity of a man who had agreed to a thing and intended to honour it. The calls lasted approximately three minutes each. In the fourth month, Malcolm answered by accident on Tyrell's phone and spoke to the ISP contact for eleven minutes about nothing in particular, and Tyrell, when told, said nothing about this, and called again the following month on schedule, and the call lasted fourteen minutes.

Lady Morganna, Scotland

She did not check in on schedule. She checked in six days late, via a method the ISP contact system did not recognise and had to spend two days reverse-engineering. The message, when decoded, said: I am well. The portraits said to tell you the one in the skull mask has impeccable posture. Wisp is moping. He has not recovered from being told hello. Wisp's mask, reportedly, brightened considerably when the message was read back to him by the field agent who had been sent to confirm receipt.

Goroth and Boulder, Sweden

The local ISP contact rotation was arranged through the Stockholm field office. The first agent sent to conduct the welfare visit returned with a report that was professionally competent and also contained, unprompted, three paragraphs about Boulder, which the Stockholm field office noted and chose not to comment on. Goroth had, by the time of the visit, repaired the cave floor. He had also, without being asked, cleared a landing area near the cave entrance large enough for a vehicle, which the field agent's report described,

carefully, as a gesture of accommodation. Boulder watched the agent leave from the cave entrance and did not charge.

Emberlash and Ravi, ISP custody

The renegotiation with Greek authorities was completed. The new agreement was more specific about the definition of operational activity, and included a clause that Emberlash had not requested but which the ISP had inserted on its own initiative: access to drawing materials for Ravi. Emberlash, when informed of this clause, said nothing. Ravi, when given the materials, spent four hours drawing a city from above, undamaged, with the careful attention of someone who had spent years looking at cities from other angles and had a specific idea of what they should look like. Emberlash, who had not been told about the drawing, asked to see it. He was shown it. He said nothing about it. The ISP agent present noted that his hands were very still.

Thark, Tanzania

He fixed the barrel. He sent the ISP a very detailed unsolicited report on the structural upgrades he had made to the chest housing, including annotated schematics, and requested that the same two agents be sent for the follow-up visit so that the upgrades could be properly stress-tested. The ISP field coordinator who received the request noted that it was, technically, a check-in, and logged it as such. Thark was informed his monthly contact was considered received. He sent back another schematic.

Kael "Shade", location unspecified

He was in the ISP file. Bás Eagla found him three days after returning to base, under a registration that had been completed eight months earlier and had since lapsed due to missed contact. The file was updated. A check-in prompt was sent. Kael responded within the hour, which was faster than most contacts responded, with a message that said: received. The armor

components from Thark had been installed. The field report noted, without editorial comment, that the components fit precisely.

Ethan Blackwood, Tokyo

He sent a message four days before the first scheduled check-in was due. It said: Wraith activity is down. She has not returned. I found someone else in the district who can partially sense them. I am going to teach her what I know. The ISP contact responded. Ethan responded to the response. The exchange lasted six messages, which was five more messages than any previous contact with him had produced. He still slept on rooftops. He still asked people if they were all right. But the asking, now, had a different quality to it, the quality of someone who had recently been asked the same thing and had not had a ready answer and was thinking about what an answer might look like.

The hardware shop owner, Shinjuku

She opened the shop the next morning and found the cracked window had been replaced overnight, cleanly and correctly, with a pane that fit the frame as if it had always been there. There was no note. She looked at it for a moment. She made tea. She opened the shop. When a young man in a hooded jacket came in later that week for tape and rope and the usual things, she put a small box of rice crackers on the counter beside his purchase without explanation. He looked at the crackers. He looked at her. He said: are you all right. She said: yes. She put the crackers in the bag. He paid. He went. She thought that some questions were their own answers, if you let them be.

The Triumphant Trinity

Ultramind filed a parallel report to the Trinity's own archive, classified above the ISP's access level, which documented the evening's events with the precision of someone who had been recording significant events for a long time and had developed a specific economy of language for doing so. At the

end of the report, in a section that was not standard, he wrote: the ISP agents are worth knowing. They held. He closed the file. He opened the Afyabalqis file, which he opened every few days, which contained everything they knew and everything they did not know, which were different categories but were both very long. He read nothing new. He closed it. He would open it again in a few days. He always did.

Velocity Vanguard sent a message to Zephyr's ISP contact address at approximately three in the morning Tokyo time, which was not three in the morning for him because he had already run to a different time zone, and the message said: the tofu place Ethan knows is genuinely excellent. I am going back tomorrow. You should come. He did not wait for a response because he was already elsewhere. The message was there in the morning.

Bás Eagla and Zephyr

The report took two days to write. It was the longest report Base 45 had received in four years. Benny Mischief, who had emerged from his invention project with the satisfied air of someone who had accomplished something and was not yet ready to disclose what, read the executive summary and said: you had an eventful week. Bás Eagla said: yes. Benny read further. He said: she is going to come back. Bás Eagla said: yes. Benny looked at the section on the Triumphant Trinity and then at the section on Nimlaser and then at the section that detailed the specific capabilities she had demonstrated and the specific assessment she had made of them before withdrawing.

He said: you are going to need to go back to Japan.

Bás Eagla said: yes.

There was a silence.

"Mr. Bobbin," Zephyr said, from the doorway of the briefing room, "is on the roof again."

Benny said: how does he get up there.

Nobody answered this. Nobody ever answered this.

Bás Eagla looked at the report on the desk in front of him, the seven welfare checks and the eighth that had become something else, and the something else that was not over. He looked at the window, which showed the Base 45 courtyard and the Chilean sky beyond it, which was very blue and very wide and entirely indifferent to the contents of the report.

Zephyr sat in the chair beside him.

They had been back at base for two days. Neither of them had slept especially well. Both of them had eaten regularly, which was an improvement on certain parts of the trip. The debrief had been long and the paperwork had been longer and Ravi's intake processing was still ongoing and Morganna's missed check-in had generated a separate administrative thread and Kael's file had required three amendments to bring it current.

"She will come back," Zephyr said, looking at the window. Not asking. Just saying it, the way you said things that were true and required acknowledgment.

"Yes," Bás Eagla said.

"And when she does, it will not be a welfare check that gets us there."

"No."

"It will be something larger."

"Yes."

Zephyr looked at the window for a moment longer.

"Good," he said.

Bás Eagla looked at him.

"Good," Zephyr said again, with the uncomplicated certainty of someone who had decided, a long time ago, that the size of a thing was not a reason to turn away from it. "We will be ready."

Above them, on the roof, Mr. Bobbin swayed in the Chilean wind, his marker-drawn smile exactly as it always was, patient and permanent and pointing at the sky.

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